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Backyard Generating Station

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One house. One backyard generating station. Electricity and heat, day and night, for 100 years.

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1. The Need

The United States is asking the grid to do two jobs at once, and it is falling behind on both.

It must make a lot more electricity: data centers, factories, electric cars, and houses switching from gas heat to electric heat. Demand that sat almost flat for twenty years is now pointed up. One recent national forecast puts use on the order of **20% higher by 2030** and **about 40% higher by the mid-2030s** ([ICF, 2026](#)). Spare generating capacity above what planners already need is already thin, a few percent of the fleet. Some of the biggest regional grids have little or no extra room.

It must also keep the lights on with wires, poles, and buried cables that were treated as permanent and are not. In 2024 the average US customer sat through about **11 hours** without power, nearly twice the yearly average of the decade before. Major weather did most of that damage. Even in ordinary years, with the big storms stripped out, the average customer still loses about **two hours** ([US Energy Information Administration](#)).

Those two facts meet at the house. The bill is rising because new plants and new wires cost money. The outages are rising because the old plant and the old wires are failing, or because the utility turns the power off on purpose when wind and dry brush make a live line a fire starter. A house that can keep its own power on is how you stay cool in a heat wave, warm in a freeze, and alive if the machine in the bedroom needs a wall outlet.

The Backyard Generating Station is one answer to that need: generation at the load, compared at the same meter to rooftop solar. This chapter is the need, not the machine.

The country is short of new power

For a long stretch, US electricity use barely grew. Efficiency hid new gadgets. That stretch is over.

The new load is lumpy and fast. A single data-center campus can ask for as much power as a small city. Car chargers and heat pumps add house by house. Seattle City Light, to take one utility that has said this publicly, expects electrical demand in its territory to **double in about twenty years**, and it is already shopping for new wind, solar, and geothermal because the old hydro will not cover it ([Seattle Times, Aug. 16, 2026](#)). That utility also needs new substations at a couple hundred million dollars each, and a multi-billion-dollar dam upgrade. The pattern is national: more load, long lead times, and towns that do not want a 1,000 MW plant next door.

When load grows faster than plants and transmission, two household results follow. Rates go up to pay for what does get built. Reserve margin goes down, so a hot afternoon or a cold week has less slack. Chapter 2 puts numbers on the bill. The need underneath those numbers is simple: the country is trying to electrify more of life on a grid that was not sized for that, and that is not being rebuilt at the same pace.

The wires are old, in many cities at once

Outages are not only hurricanes. They are also 1960s cable that was buried as if it would last forever.

Seattle is a clean example because the paper trail is public. More than **300 miles** of underground cable are decades past useful life. Replacing them is pegged at more than **\$2 billion** over at least 15 years. Average restoration time went from **78 minutes in 2014** to **145 minutes in 2024**, even with big weather events taken out, which put that utility in the worst quarter of the country for getting the lights back on. Neighborhoods that buried lines in the 1960s and 1970s for looks now lose power over and over. One Queen Anne household logged more than 20 outages after 2021, including six in the first half of a single year. A “run to failure” habit (keep rates low, fix it when it breaks) is what a former utility chief called the worst reliability she had seen in her career. The cables were never a permanent object. There was no fund waiting when the bill came due ([Seattle Times](#)).

That is one city. The same aging-and-weather pattern shows up across the map:

- **Texas, February 2021.** A winter storm and a grid that could not keep generation online left millions of homes dark in a freeze. The state later counted **246** storm-related deaths. Most were hypothermia. Others were carbon monoxide from grills and generators, house fires from space heaters, and people whose oxygen, dialysis, or other electric medical gear stopped ([Texas DSHS](#); [Texas Tribune](#)).

- **Houston and the Gulf, July 2024.** Hurricane Beryl knocked out more than **2.1 million** CenterPoint customers, about three-quarters of that territory. Restoration ran about **11 days** ([CenterPoint after-action](#)). EIA's national 2024 spike is, in large part, Beryl plus Helene plus Milton ([EIA](#)).
- **Carolinas and Florida, 2024.** Helene and Milton took down transmission, distribution, and substations. South Carolina's average customer lost on the order of **50 hours** that year, an outlier that is still a real year in a real state ([EIA](#)).
- **California, on purpose.** Utilities turn lines off when wind and dry fuel make a spark into a fire. A Public Safety Power Shutoff can run a day or two, sometimes longer, across many counties at once. Oregon, Colorado, Idaho, and Hawaii have copied the tool ([CPUC on PSPS](#)). The wire is aging and the climate is drier. The tool they use is a planned blackout.
- **Portland metro, January 2024.** Ice and wind took out hundreds of thousands of customers. Some sat in the cold for about a week. At least ten deaths were tied to that week: hypothermia, trees, lines, fires ([KGW](#)).

The national scoreboard is the EIA reliability tables: with major events included, the average customer's yearly minutes without power jumped from **342 in 2023** to **611 in 2024**. Strip the major events and you still have about **two hours** a year of ordinary failure, the everyday signature of trees, old cable, and deferred maintenance ([EIA Table 11.3](#)).

The same aging-cable problem is not limited to Seattle. It is what “run to failure” looks like when the failure arrives in a lot of cities in the same decade.

The same story, elsewhere

Aging plants and thin reserve are not only an American problem.

Spain and Portugal, April 28, 2025. A voltage collapse took down most of the Iberian grid, the worst European blackout in about twenty years. Portugal’s transmission was back in about 12 hours. Spain’s took about 16. Elevators, trains, and hospitals ran on whatever backup they had. The official investigation is public ([ENTSO-E expert panel](#)).

South Africa, years on end. Eskom’s aging coal fleet could not meet load, so the country lived on scheduled “load shedding”: hours a day, by neighborhood, for years. When the plants run better, the blackouts ease. When they do not, the schedule returns. That is what a generation shortfall looks like as an everyday schedule, not a one-week storm ([Eskom system updates](#)).

Puerto Rico. After Hurricane Maria and through the years after, an old, storm-hit grid left households on diesel and long dark stretches. It is a US territory living the end state of deferred rebuild.

The point for a US house is that a rich country is not exempt. If the plants are late and the wires are past their life, outages become ordinary. Seattle's 15-year cable program and South Africa's load-shedding calendar are the same problem at different speeds: not enough working infrastructure for the load that is already there.

How uptime saves lives

Electricity is no longer only lights and television. For a growing share of households it is a medical device, a climate-control system, and the pump that keeps water clean. When it stays on, people are less likely to die from what follows the outage: a dark house in a heat wave, a freeze, or a medical device that stops.

Heat. Air conditioning is life-safety equipment in a heat wave. Older adults, infants, and people on certain medicines cannot dump heat. A multi-day outage in July is not an inconvenience. It is a medical event in the living room. The house that keeps 8 kW on through that week is a house that keeps people out of the ER.

Cold. Texas 2021 is the large, counted case: hundreds of deaths, most from the house going as cold as the street. Portland 2024 is the smaller cousin. Space heaters and ovens used as furnaces start fires. The deaths are hypothermia and the fire, not "the storm" in the abstract.

Home medical gear. HHS tracks Medicare beneficiaries who live at home on electricity-dependent equipment: oxygen concentrators, ventilators, BiPAP, home dialysis, infusion pumps, powered beds

and chairs, implanted heart-assist devices. That electricity-dependent group is **over 3 million** people. Count those plus people who need dialysis, tank oxygen, home health, or hospice and the at-risk total is **over 4.6 million**, in every state, down to the ZIP code ([HHS emPOWER](#)). That list is Medicare only. It misses children (the Queen Anne household whose son's air purifier dies in the night), working-age adults on a CPAP or a fridge full of insulin, and anyone whose pharmacy cold-chain sits in a kitchen refrigerator. Hours without power is enough. Days is a hospital trip or worse.

The generator that kills. When the grid dies, people drag out gasoline generators, run cars in garages, and light grills indoors. Texas counted **19** carbon monoxide deaths in that one freeze. Uptime at the panel is how those people never start the motor.

Water and waste. City pumps, well pumps, and lift stations run on electricity. After a long outage you get boil-water notices, dead sewage pumps, and a house that cannot flush. Infection and dehydration follow the dark, especially for the same people already on medical gear.

The rest of the street. Traffic lights, cell sites, and 911 answering all have hours of battery or diesel, not weeks. A house that stays up does not restore the city. It keeps the people in that house off the overwhelmed hospital list while the city is down.

Seattle's story already has the small version: a toddler who coughs when the purifier stops, a parent who cannot keep the house warm, a remote class that assumes the wall outlet works. Scale that by 4.6 million Medicare households and by every heat wave and ice storm, and keeping power on is a public-health issue.

What this means at one house

A typical house uses about 10,000 to 12,000 kWh a year. A high-use house can run \$400 to \$600 a month. Chapter 2 does the bill math, including rates that are already climbing.

The need under that math is uptime and capacity in the same object.

Rooftop solar at that house makes power when the sun is out. In a heat wave that can help in the afternoon. At night, in an ice storm, in a week of coastal weather, or during a Public Safety Power Shutoff, the array is a cold roof. A battery helps for hours, not for a Texas week, unless something is still filling it.

The Backyard Generating Station is sized to keep filling that battery in the dark: 5 to 10 kWe, plus heat the house can use. It does not replace a national rebuild of 300 miles of Seattle cable or a new 1,000 MW plant. It is how one family stays on while that rebuild is 15 years out, and how that family adds a slice of supply the country is short of, at the place the load already is.

If the country is heading into a decade or two of tight reserve and old wires, the house that can run through an outage is the house that does not add a hypothermia death, a heat stroke, a silent oxygen concentrator, or a generator in the garage to the tally.

What this chapter covered

This is the need: more electricity, older wires, longer dark hours, and a medical dependence on the outlet that did not exist at this scale when the 1960s cable went in. The examples are Seattle, Texas, Houston, the Carolinas, California, Portland, and the same failure mode abroad. The life-safety case is heat, cold, home medical gear, carbon monoxide, and water. Chapter 2 is the product and the payback.

2. The Idea

A house should be able to make its own power, keep the lights on in a storm, heat the rooms it already knows how to heat, and sell what it does not use. It should do that without covering the roof in solar panels, without depending on roof seals that can leak for 25 years, and without a fuel truck in the driveway.

That is the Backyard Generating Station: a sealed, factory-built appliance, about the size of a large septic tank, with **ten feet of soil above the lid**. American yards already bury tanks this way (septic tanks, underground propane, heating-oil tanks). Ten feet of cover is on the deep side of that habit, closer to a large buried fuel tank than to a shallow septic lid. The object itself needs about a **10 by 10 foot** patch of yard. How far it sits from the house is a local permit question.

A licensed crew installs it once. Nobody on the property ever opens it. It makes electricity for the house, stores the extra in a wall battery, sends overflow to the grid, and offers leftover heat to the heating system many newer American homes already have.

It is meant to be compared, at the same address, to rooftop solar: what you pay, what you maintain, what you get, and what you can sell back.

What it is

The station is a lead-lined concrete vault, about the size and weight class of the buried tanks already common in American yards. A small excavator digs the hole. A crane sets the vault. The crew puts ten feet of soil back on the lid and the grass goes back on top. It is never serviced in place. It is designed to run for on the order of a century and then be lifted out as one piece.

Above ground you see almost nothing. Heat and a few wires reach the house through a **chase**: a buried pipe run from the underside of the vault to a **utility room**. That room can be in the house (a basement, a garage wall) or a small shed next to it. The house sees four familiar things:

- a circuit that feeds the electrical panel, the same way a backup generator or a solar system does
- a wall battery that stores extra electricity so the house can use more than the station is making at that exact moment (oven, dryer, and air conditioner at once)
- an inverter, the same kind of box a solar install uses, that turns the station's output into ordinary house current and talks to the utility
- a closed water loop, where the house can use it, that hands leftover heat to systems that already run on hot water

The homeowner does not operate a plant. They own an appliance.

How big this is

Power is easier to feel with a few anchors.

A typical American house uses about 10,000 to 12,000 kWh in a year (kilowatt-hours: how much energy you used over time). That is, on average, a little over 1 kW (kilowatts: how hard power is flowing right now), all day, every day, and can spike to 10 or 20 kW when the air conditioner, range, and dryer hit at once.

Some houses use much more. A high-use house can run **\$400 to \$600 a month** for electricity (**about \$5,000 to \$7,000 a year**). That is more kilowatt-hours, a higher price per kWh, or both. At ordinary rates that is on the order of 20,000 to 35,000 kWh a year, an average of about 2.5 to 4 kW, with the same kind of evening spikes. The Backyard Generating Station is sized for that high end as well as for the typical house.

Rooftop solar on that same house is usually an 8 to 12 kW array. On a good sun day it can outrun the house. At night, and through a week of coastal weather, it makes nothing. That is why solar quotes always include the roof, the weather, and a battery if you want the house to keep working after dark.

A utility-scale solar farm is the same idea, multiplied: tens or hundreds of megawatts (1 MW = 1,000 kW), spread over fields, feeding the grid rather than one kitchen.

A typical commercial generating station of the large kind most people picture is about 1,000 MW. That is a million kilowatts, enough, in round numbers, for several hundred thousand homes. It is a campus: cooling towers, switchyards, a security perimeter, a staff.

The Backyard Generating Station sits at the house end of that range. It is sized for **5 to 10 kW_e** (kilowatts of electricity: the “e” just means this number is electrical output, not heat) of steady output. Next to a 1,000 MW plant that is about **1/100,000 to 1/200,000** the electrical size. It is a home-furnace-scale heat source that also makes power. That is why it belongs in a yard the way a buried tank does, and why it is not a commercial plant next door.

It is in the same size class as a rooftop solar array, except it keeps making power when the sun is out and when it is not.

It does not try to match the 20 kW spike. The battery does that. The station keeps charging the battery. When the battery is full and the house has what it needs, extra power goes to the grid.

A note on the units. kW is the size of the pipe. kWh is the water that went through it. If the station makes 8 kW for one hour, that is 8 kWh, about what a central air conditioner uses in an hour, or a little less than a day’s worth of a modest house that is not heating or cooling hard. Over a year, 8 kW running most of the time is on the order of 70,000 kWh. A typical house that uses 12,000 kWh has a lot left to sell. A high-use house that uses 20,000 to 35,000 kWh still has tens of thousands of kWh left to sell, or to put into a second car, a workshop, or a storm reserve.

What	Typical size	What that means
House, typical average	~1 kW	About 24 kWh/day, or 10,000 to 12,000 kWh/year. About \$2,000 a year at 18¢/kWh.
House, high-use average	~2.5 to 4 kW	About 20,000 to 35,000 kWh/year. About \$5,000 to \$7,000 a year (\$400 to \$600 a month).
House, peak	10 to 20 kW	Air conditioner, range, and dryer at once. The battery covers this.
Rooftop solar	8 to 12 kW	Same house-scale neighborhood. Makes power only when the sun is out.
Backyard Generating Station	5 to 10 kWe	Same neighborhood as rooftop solar, as a steady output, sun or not.
Utility solar farm	tens to hundreds of MW	Fields. Feeds the grid, not one kitchen. (1 MW = 1,000 kW)
Large commercial station	~1,000 MW	A campus. About 100,000 to 200,000 times the electrical size of this unit.

You do not need to build a 1,000 MW commercial station to serve those several hundred thousand households. You can build one right-sized unit per house and serve the need where the load already is, the same placement idea as a rooftop solar array, without the campus, the cooling towers, or the long wires in between. Rooftop solar already shows that house-scale generation is a normal way to site power. The station is the version that still works when the sun does not.

A day in the life

The station runs as a quiet, steady source. The battery covers the short spikes.

Morning: the house wakes up. The battery covers the coffee-and-shower bump. The station is already making power, so the battery does not drain far.

Afternoon: the house is light. The battery fills. If it is full, the inverter exports to the meter the same way a solar system does.

Evening: oven, laundry, screens. The battery covers the peak. The station keeps topping it off. On the off chance the house wants more than the battery still holds (a rare, hard spike), the panel just pulls the rest from the grid, the same way it does today. The lights do not go out. You buy a bit of power for an hour instead of a whole day's worth.

Night: same as afternoon, except solar is not making power. This is the like-for-like point versus solar. Compare yearly kilowatt-hours at this house, plus what still works when the weather is bad.

Heat is a second product of the same day. The station makes electricity and warmth together. In winter that warmth heats the house. In summer the house may only want showers, or it can send the rest to a greenhouse. Later chapters treat the hardware. The idea is simple: use the warmth where a pipe can take it.

Heat the house already knows how to use

A lot of newer houses in the United States already heat with hot water in pipes, in the floor, in a tank, or in a coil, not only with hot air blown through vents.

The station never mixes its insides with the house. Heat crosses through a sealed metal exchanger: two water loops share warmth through a wall, and the waters never touch. A home boiler already works this way. What the house already has can take that water:

- **Radiant floors.** Plastic heating pipe (PEX) in a slab or under a floor typically wants water in a modest range, roughly 80 to 120°F. That is the temperature leftover warmth can supply. It is not furnace-flame temperature.
- **Indirect tanks and buffer tanks.** Many boiler rooms already have a tank with a coil in it. The station can be the thing that keeps that tank hot, for showers and laundry, and as stored heat for the heating loop.
- **Hydro-air.** Some houses have both a boiler and ducts. A coil of hot-water pipe sits in the air handler (the big box that already blows air through the house). The station heats that coil. The thermostat and the blower stay the same.
- **A high-efficiency boiler loop.** Newer houses with a condensing boiler already have a hot-water piping loop. The station ties in as a second heat source, isolated, and the boiler becomes backup or peak.

- **Air-to-water heat pumps.** A growing share of new work uses a heat pump to warm a tank of water. The station can preheat that tank so the heat pump does less work, or carry the load when that is the better choice.
- **A greenhouse.** If the house has no hot-water heating loop, or if it does not want the warmth in summer, the same loop can run to a greenhouse. Year-round vegetables and fruit become possible in climates and geographies that would not support that on sunlight and a furnace bill alone. The house still gets the electricity. The plants get the heat.

Houses that are all electric baseboard, or mini-splits with no water loop, still get electricity, battery, and grid sale. They can still take a standalone tank for showers and laundry. They do not get whole-house space heat unless someone adds hot-water piping, or they put the warmth into a greenhouse instead. If the house already has a boiler room or a radiant-floor manifold, the station connects to that hardware. If it does not, you are buying a power appliance. Space heat is then a choice: add piping, add a greenhouse, or use the electricity only.

Winter heating for a typical house is often in the 5 to 15 kW range. A station making 5 to 10 kW of electricity will also be making a couple of times that in heat. That is enough, on many days, to run the floors and the water heater without lighting the old boiler.

Living with it

Day to day there is nothing to do. The station keeps making power. The battery tops itself off. Extra goes to the grid. Heat follows the thermostat the house already has. When you leave, the setback you already use is enough.

An app is not required. The thermostat and the utility meter are enough. If you install one on a phone or a tablet, it is only a status window, the same habit solar owners already have: what the station made, what the house used, what was sold, what is in the battery. It can make those numbers easier to see. It does not run the station. It has no modes and no switches that start, stop, or change the vault.

How it makes power

The vault holds a very small nuclear core. Heat comes from splitting atoms in a sealed fuel, at a scale closer to a large home furnace than to a commercial station.

That heat does two jobs for the house at the same time. It makes electricity for the panel. It can also warm rooms, showers, or a greenhouse. Using both is the design. If the house or a greenhouse uses the warmth, most of what the core makes is used, not thrown away.

The numbers stay small on purpose.

A house-scale electrical output of 5 to 10 kW goes with about **20 to 40 kW of heat** from the core. That is furnace scale, not power-plant scale. After the unit is shut down, the leftover heat that has to go

somewhere drops to about as much as a small space heater, then lower over the following hours and days. Dirt, concrete, and time can take that. There is no cooling tower.

Fuel use at this output, over a century, is measured in kilograms, not tons: about **30 kilograms (about 66 pounds) at first start**, a paint-can of heavy metal inside a beer-keg-to-dishwasher-sized core, itself inside the septic-tank vault. By the end of life, on the order of 15 to 25 kilograms of that heavy metal has been used up. Chapter 8 is the arithmetic. The vault is the thing the crane sees. The core is never a backyard project.

Because the core is run cold and slow (a trickle of heat in a lot of mass), it can be built for a very long sealed life. Material mixed into the fuel is used up as the fuel is used up, so the output stays even. There is no refueling truck. There is no hatch for the owner.

The fuel and the core are built so heat itself slows the reaction: hotter means less splitting, in milliseconds, without a person or a motor. That is the ordinary safety case. A last-ditch layer above the core can melt and set into a glass-like mass if the vault ever got far hotter than it should. That is not expected to run. The design is meant to never get there. The unit is too small for leftover heat to run away, it sits in earth, and it does not rely on a pump staying on.

From the factory to first power

The vault is not “on” when it is built, and it is not on when it rides on a truck.

Fresh fuel has never been used, so it is not already hot. In the factory the core is assembled in a shutdown state: locks and control elements are in the position that keeps it from making heat. The vault is sealed around that. What leaves the plant is a heavy, closed object that is not producing electricity and not producing heat.

It is trucked like other permitted heavy freight and set with a crane. The crew connects the house wires, the inverter, the battery, and, if the house will use it, the water loop. Inspectors sign off.

Only after it is buried and connected does a licensed startup happen. The shutdown locks are released in a controlled procedure. That is the first time the core makes heat. Until that step the vault is cold. At the end of life the same locks go back in before the crane returns.

This is also why a size-based path is part of the idea. A 1,000 MW station is a power plant. A 20 to 40 kW heat source in a factory-sealed vault is an appliance, about 1/100,000 the electrical size of that plant. The project's aim is not to site a campus behind a house. It is to get a manufactured, never-opened unit approved, or exempted, because it is this small, installed by licensed people, and left closed until a licensed crew takes it away.

What it costs

These are high-level bands for a production unit, not a first prototype. Early units cost more. The check you write is in today's dollars. The bill you stop paying will not stay at today's rate. The

country is heading into a stretch where most regions will be short of power, and the cents you pay per kWh have been rising and are expected to keep rising. That rising rate belongs in the cost picture.

The station itself. The sealed vault is the manufactured product. In volume, think in the same world as a serious whole-home energy project: tens of thousands of dollars, not hundreds of thousands, once it is a factory object rather than a custom machine. The first ones will not be that.

Setting it. A contractor digs a hole deep enough for the vault plus **ten feet of soil on the lid**, a crane sets the vault, and the crew beds and buries it. The grass footprint is about **10 by 10 feet**. The vault has to be able to sit wet, because a lot of yards will flood in the life of the unit. In ordinary soil that buried-tank job is often **\$10,000 to \$20,000**. If the crew hits rock, or the hole fills with groundwater, the same work can run **\$25,000 to \$40,000**.

Power tie-in. Panel work, the inverter, and the utility hookup: the same class of electrical work as a solar install. Roughly **\$8,000 to \$15,000**, depending on the service and the utility.

Stirling engines. Five sealed 2 kWe convertors in the utility room (10 kWe installed, 8 kWe used, one spare). They sit next to the inverter, not in the vault. Each unit is about the size of a large fire extinguisher (about 12 inches across and 18 inches tall, about 110 pounds). Five of them, plus the oil pump and the heat exchanger, fit a basement utility room or a small shed. They do not fit in a closet next to the panel.

Today, at low volume, that set is about **\$40,000 to \$100,000** (about \$8,000 to \$20,000 per engine). If they become an ordinary factory part, a working target is **\$15,000 to \$30,000** for the set. That first set is part of the install check. They last about **10 to 15 years** and get swapped in that room. The swap is a later check, like a furnace. It is not in the simple-payback tables below.

Battery. Two or three wall units in the Tesla-class size (about 13 kWh each) to cover peaks and a storm night: often **\$20,000 to \$40,000** installed. This is the same kind of line item solar already has if you want the house to work after dark.

Heat tie-in. If the house already has a radiant-floor manifold, a hot-water tank, or a boiler loop, an isolated exchanger and controls are a few thousand dollars to about **\$10,000**. If the house has no hot-water heating pipes, you either skip space heat, add a tank and piping on purpose, or run a loop to a greenhouse.

All-in at a house that can use the heat:

- **Early production:** **\$130,000 to \$260,000** is the honest band while the vault is still a new manufactured object and the Stirling set is still a low-volume part (**\$40,000 to \$100,000** of that band).
- **Factory scale** (the vault is an ordinary appliance, built in numbers): a working target is **\$70,000 to \$125,000** all-in. The vault gets cheaper. The hole, the Stirling set (**\$15,000 to \$30,000**), the inverter, and the batteries do not vanish.

- **With a government credit like the one solar received** (a federal investment tax credit, often 30% in solar's early years, applied to the generating equipment, including the Stirling set): early production could net in a **\$90,000 to \$180,000** band, and factory scale in a **\$50,000 to \$90,000** band. That credit is a policy path, not a promise. Solar got one because the country wanted more carbon-free generation at the house. The same argument applies here, with a second one: every house-scale station is a house that does not need a new 1,000 MW plant sited in someone else's town. Communities already refuse those plants. The United States already generates almost all of the electricity it uses; the stronger public case is carbon-free power at the load, fewer giant stations, and a factory product that does not depend on a roof full of imported panels.

What a house uses, and how long the check takes to come back

Household electricity is a range, not one number. Some months are higher (air conditioning, electric heat) and some are lower. The yearly total is what payback uses.

- **Typical house:** about **10,000 to 12,000 kWh a year** (about 900 kWh a month). At a recent US average of about **18 cents per kWh**, that is about **\$2,000 a year**, or about \$160 to \$170 a month. Space heat and hot water are often a second bill of **\$800 to \$2,000 a year** if they are not already on that electric meter.

- **High-use house:** about **\$400 to \$600 a month**, or **\$5,000 to \$7,000 a year**. A \$560 month is about \$6,700 a year. That may be 20,000 to 35,000 kWh (a bigger house, more electric loads), a higher cents-per-kWh rate, or both. On a bill this large, electric heat or a heat pump is often already inside the \$560. Do not add a second heat line on top unless the house still pays a separate gas or oil bill.

The Backyard Generating Station is sized at 5 to 10 kWe of steady output. At 8 kWe, running most of the year:

$$8 \text{ kW} \times 8,760 \text{ hours in a year} \approx 70,000 \text{ kWh}$$

A typical house keeps about 11,000 kWh of that and can sell about **59,000 kWh**. A high-use house keeps about 20,000 to 35,000 kWh and can still sell **35,000 to 50,000 kWh**. Either way, 8 to 10 kWe covers the high end; 5 kWe is a tighter fit if the house averages near 4 kW.

Rooftop solar at the same house is usually an 8 to 12 kW array. It makes about **10,000 to 14,000 kWh a year** on a decent roof, and less on a shaded, cloudy, or low-sun roof. That can match a typical house and not much leftover. On a high-use house it covers only part of the bill. It does not make space heat unless the house already heats with electricity.

So the two systems are not the same size in delivered energy. Solar is built to match a typical house. The Backyard Generating Station, if it runs as a steady 8 kW, makes several times even a high-use

house's electric load. Payback then depends on two prices: what you no longer pay the utility (and any leftover heating fuel), and what the utility pays you for the extra.

Simple payback is cost divided by a year's savings **at today's rate**, as if the bill never moved. That is the snapshot in the tables below. It overstates the years if rates keep climbing, which they have been. These are round numbers for a factory-scale Backyard Generating Station after a solar-style 30% credit (**\$50,000 to \$90,000**, including the first Stirling set), next to a complete solar-plus-battery job at the same meter.

Typical house (~\$2,000 electric bill):

	What you pay (net)	Electricity made in a year	A year's savings (round)	Simple payback
Solar + battery, ordinary roof	\$35,000 to \$55,000	10,000 to 14,000 kWh (about what the house uses)	About \$2,000 (the electric bill)	12 to 20 years
Solar + battery, shaded, cloudy, or low-sun roof	\$35,000 to \$55,000, sometimes more	Less than the house uses	About \$1,200 to \$1,800	25 to 30 years
Backyard Generating Station, extra paid near the retail rate (~18¢/kWh)	\$50,000 to \$90,000	~70,000 kWh	About \$12,000 to \$14,000 (bill + heat + sell-back)	4 to 8 years
Backyard Generating Station, extra paid at a lower wholesale-style rate (~5¢/kWh)	\$50,000 to \$90,000	~70,000 kWh	About \$5,000 to \$7,000	7 to 18 years
Backyard Generating Station, extra paid nothing (house offset and heat only)	\$50,000 to \$90,000	~70,000 kWh	About \$2,800 to \$4,000	13 to 32 years

High-use house (~\$5,000 to \$7,000 electric bill, about \$400 to \$600 a month):

	What you pay (net)	Electricity made in a year	A year's savings (round)	Simple payback
Solar + battery, ordinary roof	\$35,000 to \$55,000	10,000 to 14,000 kWh (only part of the bill)	About \$2,000 to \$3,000	15 to 25 years
Solar + battery, shaded, cloudy, or low-sun roof	\$35,000 to \$55,000, sometimes more	Less than that	About \$1,200 to \$2,000	25 to 40 years
Backyard Generating Station, extra paid near the retail rate	\$50,000 to \$90,000	~70,000 kWh	About \$12,000 to \$16,000 (the \$5,000 to \$7,000 bill plus sell-back)	3 to 8 years
Backyard Generating Station, extra paid at a lower wholesale-style rate (~5¢/kWh)	\$50,000 to \$90,000	~70,000 kWh	About \$8,000 to \$10,000	5 to 11 years
Backyard Generating Station, extra paid nothing (house offset only)	\$50,000 to \$90,000	~70,000 kWh	About \$5,000 to \$7,000	7 to 18 years

Solar's problem on a high-use house is simple: the array still makes about 10,000 to 14,000 kWh, so most of a \$6,700 bill remains. The Backyard Generating Station's problem is still the sell-back price, not whether it can cover the house.

The grid is getting short, and the rate is going up

For about twenty years, US electricity use was almost flat. That stretch is over. Data centers, factories, electric cars, and houses switching from gas to electric heat are adding load faster than new plants and transmission are getting built. Demand is on track to be on the order of **20% higher by 2030** and **about 40% higher by the mid-2030s**. The spare generating capacity sitting above what the grid already needs is already thin (a few percent nationally). Some of the biggest regional grids already have little or no extra room. New 1,000 MW stations take years and are the plants communities

already refuse. So for the next decade to a few decades, most places in the country are more likely to be short of power than swimming in it.

When the grid is short, two things happen to a household bill.

The cents per kWh go up. They already have. The US residential average has climbed from the low teens (cents per kWh) a decade ago to about **18 cents** now, and recent years have been on the order of **4% to 6% a year**. Forecasts for the rest of this decade often land in a **15% to 40% higher bill by 2030**, depending on the utility: more plants, more wires, and more competition from big new loads. A \$2,000 typical bill becomes about \$2,300 to \$2,800. A \$6,700 high-use bill becomes about \$7,700 to \$9,400. After that, the climb does not automatically stop.

The kilowatt-hour you do not buy is worth more each year. Simple payback pretends year 10 is still \$2,000 or \$6,700. It is not. At 5% a year, a \$6,700 bill is about **\$10,900 in ten years**. Every year you are not paying it, the savings get larger, so the remaining balance on the \$50,000 to \$90,000 check shrinks faster than the frozen-rate tables show.

A compact way to see it: same \$50,000 to \$90,000 Backyard Generating Station (factory scale, after credit, first Stirling set included), same solar jobs, if the rate rises about **5% a year** (in the middle of the recent pace):

	Frozen-rate payback (tables above)	If rates rise ~5%/year
Solar + battery, typical house, ordinary roof	12 to 20 years	10 to 16 years
Solar + battery, typical house, weak roof	25 to 30 years	18 to 24 years
Solar + battery, high-use house, ordinary roof	15 to 25 years	12 to 20 years
Solar + battery, high-use house, weak roof	25 to 40 years	18 to 30 years
Backyard Generating Station, typical house, extra paid ~5¢	7 to 18 years	6 to 13 years
Backyard Generating Station, typical house, extra paid nothing	13 to 32 years	10 to 20 years
Backyard Generating Station, high-use house, extra paid ~5¢	5 to 11 years	4 to 9 years
Backyard Generating Station, high-use house, extra paid nothing	7 to 18 years	6 to 13 years

Retail-rate sell-back rows are still a handful of years (**4 to 8** typical, **3 to 8** high-use). Rising rates shave those too. The bigger move is in the rows that look slow at a frozen rate. A typical house with no sell-back is **13 to 32 years** if the rate never moves, and about **10 to 20 years** if it rises 5% a year. A high-use house with no sell-back is **7 to 18 years** frozen, and about **6 to 13 years** if rates rise.

Solar also gets a shorter payback when rates rise. It only gets that help on the 10,000 to 14,000 kWh it actually makes. The Backyard Generating Station gets it on the whole house bill, and on whatever extra the utility still pays for. On a high-use house, solar still covers only part of a rising bill. The station can cover the whole bill.

A short grid also changes what extra power is worth. If the country is short, a house that can sell 35,000 to 59,000 kWh is offering power the system needs. That does not guarantee the utility will pay the full retail rate. It does make the “utility pays nothing” row less likely to stay true for decades, and it makes wholesale-style rates more likely to rise along with retail. Later chapters can put a real tariff on that. The frozen-rate tables are the conservative picture.

A short grid also means the house may still have power when the region does not have enough. A Backyard Generating Station plus a battery makes power at the house. It does not wait on a plant that has not been built yet.

What still decides the years is three ordinary things: what the utility pays you for extra power, how large the house bill is, and how fast that rate climbs. Batteries wear out and get replaced. The Stirling set does too, on a 10 to 15 year clock. That is true for solar-plus-battery as well (the battery), and those later swaps are not in the tables above. The first Stirling set is in the \$50,000 to \$90,000 install number. Later chapters can put a real utility price and a real heat load on one address. At \$50,000 to \$90,000, against a range from a ~\$2,000 typical bill to a ~\$5,000 to \$7,000 high-use bill, in a country that is getting short of plants and is already raising rates,

the Backyard Generating Station's payback gets better with time. Solar's payback is still limited by how much of that rising bill the roof can actually cover.

Owner maintenance is in the **utility room**, not in the hole. The battery, the inverter, the Stirling set, and a pump wear on a decade scale and get swapped in that room. The buried vault is never opened or serviced in the yard. There is no filter to change on it, no roof work, and no oil change.

When it is done

Nothing is opened in the yard.

At the end of life, or if a unit is swapped early, a licensed crew cranes the vault out as one piece and sets the next one in the same hole. Digging can take a day or two. During that work an existing house stays on the utility, the same way it did before the station was there. The homeowner is without the station (and, if the crew has to open the panel, without house power) only for the **hours** it takes to lock the old vault, lift it, set the new one, and land the pipes and wires again. The battery can cover part of that window. A first install on a new house can take days. That is a construction week. The house can stay on the utility while the crew works. The old vault goes to a licensed facility. Shielding, metal, and concrete are recycled or reused where that is possible. The homeowner does not store, cut, or dispose of anything.

The fuel that did the work began as about 30 kilograms (66 pounds) of heavy metal. After a century, what cannot be recycled or reused is still in that size class: a paint-can receptacle at a licensed site. It does not stay on the property. The septic-tank vault was almost all shield and box. That is what the crane was for.

A replacement price should be sold as a **swap**: new unit, removal, haul, and processing of the old one, plus the reconnect. It should not be a surprise line item after someone has lived with the appliance for decades. Whether that is a prepaid end-of-life fee, an included core-exchange, or a posted swap tariff is a later-chapter question. For this chapter: replacement means the old station leaves, and the cost of that leaving is part of the replacement price. The household does not dispose of the vault.

Benefits

- **Power that does not depend on the roof or the weather.** Nights, storms, and long gray stretches are ordinary running conditions.
- **A like-for-like bill versus solar.** Same house, same meter, same battery habit, plus heat if the house can take it, compared on delivered energy and sell-back, not on panel count.
- **Heat the house can already use, or a greenhouse if it cannot.** Floors, tanks, air-handler coils, boiler loops, or year-round growing.
- **Sell-back when the battery is full.** The electrical path is the one solar already uses.

- **No holes in the roof.** No array in a wind corridor. No 25-year dependence on roof seals.
 - **No fuel deliveries for the life of the unit.**
 - **No day-to-day operation.** The thermostat and the utility meter are enough. An app, if you want one, is a status screen on a phone or tablet. It does not control the vault.
 - **An install towns already know how to permit.** A buried concrete vault, a crane, backfill.
 - **A size that is meant to be regulated as an appliance.** The whole point of staying at house scale is a path that does not look like siting a 1,000 MW campus.
 - **A path that can sit next to the solar tax credit.** Carbon-free generation at the house, and fewer new commercial stations that communities do not want nearby.
 - **Power at the house while the country is getting short.** Demand is rising faster than plants are being built. Rates have been climbing about 4% to 6% a year. A unit that covers the whole bill, not a slice of it, gets more valuable as that happens.
 - **A clean end.** One lift, one replacement, processing included in the swap. Recycle and reuse where possible. What cannot be processed fits a paint-can receptacle after a 100-year life.
-

Detriments

- **Early units will be expensive.** The first Stirling set is a real line (\$40,000 to \$100,000 today). A complete solar-plus-battery job at the same house is the fair price comparison, not a panel-only ad. Solar's first years were also expensive, and a federal credit (often 30%) brought the net cost down. The same kind of credit could apply here. Until it does, and until the vault and the engines are factory objects, the check is large.
- **The Stirling set wears out.** About every 10 to 15 years the five engines get swapped in the utility room. That later check is not in the simple-payback tables. The first set is.
- **It is not a weekend homeowner project.** It needs permits, a licensed set, a utility hookup, and extra piping if you want the heat in the house or in a greenhouse.
- **Not every house can use the heat indoors without added hardware.** Mini-splits and electric baseboard still get electricity. Whole-house space heat needs hot-water pipes, or the warmth goes to a greenhouse, showers, or a dedicated cooler.

- **In summer the house often does not want the warmth.** The station is still making heat while it makes electricity. If that heat is not sent to showers or a greenhouse, it has to be dumped on purpose through a small outdoor radiator (the same kind of box a heat pump already uses on the side of a house). If it is not dumped on purpose, it soaks into the soil around the vault. That does not heat the neighborhood, but that patch of yard runs warmer than the rest of the lot, and a vault close to the house can make the air conditioner work a little harder. August heat has to be planned. It is not unused warmth you can ignore.
 - **The first approval does not exist yet.** Size-based approval is the plan. No regulator has issued that stamp.
 - **The buried unit is a controlled object.** It is sealed and heavy on purpose. That is a benefit for the household and a responsibility for the people who make, move, and take it back.
 - **End of life is specialized.** The swap includes removal and processing at a licensed facility. Leftover fuel is small (a paint-can class receptacle), but it is not handled like a stack of old solar panels.
 - **Insurance, appraisal, and resale will have to treat this as a normal house feature.** Solar already went through that. Until this one is common, a buried vault plus a utility room will be a new line on a homeowners policy and a new note on an appraisal, the way solar panels once were.
 - **Public comfort will take time.** A septic-tank-sized vault in the yard will need a clear, measurable safety story, not only a specification sheet.
-

What this chapter covered

This is the idea at house scale, and only house scale: one family, one yard, one meter, compared to solar at that same meter. The later chapters are 3 Yard Safety, 4 The House, 5 The Vault, 6 The Approval, and 7 The Swap. The claim here is that the physics is in the right size class, the house already has ways to use the heat, the owner's life can stay simple, and the end of the story is a licensed crew and a crane.

3. Yard Safety

The claim

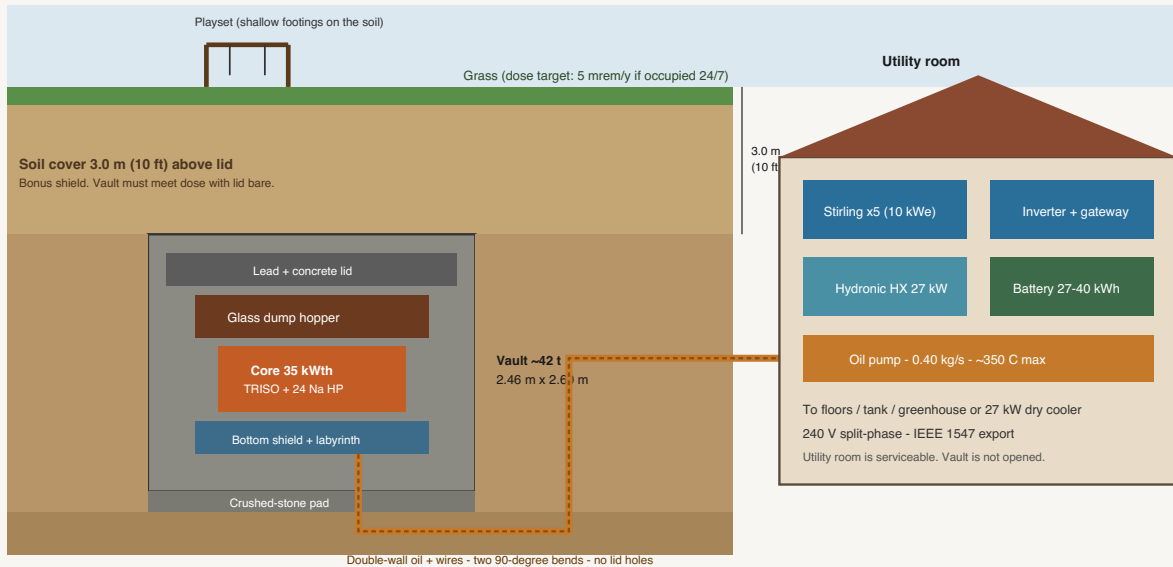
The yard stays usable: grass, a walk, a playset. The Backyard Generating Station sits under **ten feet of soil**, inside a lead-lined concrete vault. That cover is the same idea as other tanks American yards already bury (septic tanks, underground propane, heating-oil tanks). Ten feet on the lid is on the deep side of that habit, closer to a large buried fuel tank than to a shallow septic lid.

The extra dose is meant to be **a few mrem a year if a person lived on the grass over the vault, all day, every day**. That is the conservative number: someone camping on that spot for 8,760 hours. Nobody does that. A playset is an hour here and there. At one hour a day for a year, the extra is a **small fraction of one cross-country flight**, not a flight.

That is the design target. The vault does the stopping. The ten feet of dirt is extra. The numbers in this chapter, and in Chapter 8, are written as if that dirt washed off. If the lawn is still safe with a bare lid, it is safe with a playset on ten feet of soil.

Figure 1. Site section, BGS-8 (not to construction scale)

10 ft (3.0 m) of soil above the lid. Vault 2.46 m OD x 2.60 m H. Chase floor-only, two 90-degree bends. Utility room is replaceable.



What a few mrem means

Dose is how much radiation energy a body absorbs. The everyday US unit is the **mrem** (millirem: one-thousandth of a rem). People already get a dose every year from the sky, the dirt, and the air in the house. That ordinary background in the United States is on the order of **300 mrem a year**. It is higher in the mountains than at the coast. It changes from house to house.

A few mrem a year on top of that, **for a person who lived on the grass**, is about **one percent of background**, or less. That full-time lawn number is in the same size class as **one cross-country flight**. It is far below the usual public limit for a licensed source, which is **100 mrem a year** from that source.

A note on the units. mrem is a yearly kind of number when we talk about a lawn. A survey meter on the grass reads a rate (how hard it is right now). Multiply that rate by the hours you actually stand there, and you get the year's extra. The design uses the hardest case: every hour of the year on that spot. A playset uses a slice of those hours.

One hour a day is 365 hours out of 8,760, about **4% of the year**:

a few mrem/year (if you lived there) $\times (365 / 8,760) \approx 0.15$ to 0.2 mrem/year

That is about one-fifteenth to one-twentieth of one coast-to-coast flight.

What	About how much	What that means
Ordinary US background	~300 mrem/year	Sky, dirt, and house air. Already happening.
Extra if a person lived on the grass over the vault, 24/7	a few mrem/year, if it is measurable at all	The design target. About 1% of background. About one cross-country flight, spread over the whole year.
Extra for a child on a playset ~1 hour a day	~0.15 to 0.2 mrem/year	A fraction of one flight, not a flight.
Public limit from a licensed source	100 mrem/year	A ceiling, not a goal. The vault is built well below it.
Cross-country flight	a few mrem	One trip. Same size as the live-on-the-lawn number, much larger than the playset number.

Nothing shields to zero, and the yard already has background. **The vault is built so the lawn does not become a special place.** You should not need a fence or a keep-off sign.

What has to be stopped

The vault holds a small nuclear core. While it is on, two kinds of radiation try to leave: **gammas** (like very hard X-rays) and **neutrons** (heavy, uncharged particles from splitting atoms). After it is shut down, leftover heat fades and the neutron problem fades with it. Gammas from the used fuel stay inside the same vault.

Gammas are stopped by dense things. Lead and thick concrete are the point of the lining. A few inches of lead and a thick concrete wall cut gammas by a huge factor. Ten feet of dirt on top cut them again.

Neutrons are the harder yard problem. They do not care much about lead. They slow down when they hit light atoms, especially **hydrogen**. That slowing is called moderation. Once they are slow, boron or more hydrogen can catch them. Wet dirt has water, and water is hydrogen. Dry dirt has much less.

So:

- **The vault** (lead, concrete, and a hydrogen-rich layer such as concrete or a boron mix) is the shield that has to work on its own.
- **The soil** is a bonus layer. Wet soil is a better bonus than dry soil, because of that hydrogen.
- **Dry soil is the worse case.** Neutrons travel farther in dry sand or a drought-baked lot than in damp ground. The dose on the grass must still be a few mrem a year in that worse case, and with the lid bare. Wet years and ten feet of cover are then extra margin, not the thing you counted on.

If someone built a thin vault and counted on ten feet of damp dirt to do the real work, a dry summer or a washed-out lid would show it. That is not this design. The vault is sized as if the dirt dried out and then left.

How it sits in the hole

Ten feet down means **ten feet of soil above the lid**, not ten feet to the middle of the core. The vault is about eight and a half feet tall, about the size of a large septic tank. The hole is deeper than that: vault plus ten feet of cover, on the order of eighteen feet to the pad. Towns already permit deep buried tanks. The grass still only sees a **10 by 10 foot** patch. How far that patch sits from the house is a local permit question, the same as a septic tank or a buried propane tank.

The vault is the object the crane sets. It is sealed. Nobody on the lot opens it. Heat and power leave through pipes and cables, not through a hatch in the lid.

Those pipes and cables do not come out the top, under the playset. They leave through the **bottom** of the vault, then turn and run sideways in a buried **chase** toward the house. A chase is just that buried run: two heat pipes and a few wires in a trench, the same idea as a sewer lateral or a buried propane line.

That path is a design choice, for these reasons:

- Radiation that finds a hole prefers a straight line. A hole in the lid would point at the grass. A hole in the floor points at more earth.

- Earth is a thick, cheap dump. What goes down is swallowed by dirt and water in the soil.
- The chase then bends (down, over, then toward the house) so there is no straight shot back up to the lawn.
- The house still gets heat and power. The connections are at the house end of the chase, in the utility room, where a plumber and an electrician already work.

A particle can bounce. The underside chase makes the easy path point into the ground, and it keeps holes out of the lid. Frost, wet soil, and a path a crew can service at the house end are ordinary buried-line problems. They do not put a hole under a child's feet.

Why a playset is the right test

A playset is hours, not minutes, and it is children, and it is right on the grass. If that is acceptable, a walk across the yard is not a special event.

The dose target is a yearly number on the grass **as if someone lived there**. A child on a playset is a few feet higher than the grass. Air does not shield much, so each hour on the set is about the same as an hour on the lawn, maybe a little less because they are farther from the lid.

They are not living on the set. One hour a day is about 4% of the live-there number. If living on the grass is a few mrem a year (about one flight), the playset year is a **fraction of that flight**. The rest of their year (the house, the car, an actual flight, a town at a different altitude) already moves the number by more than the playset does.

Two practical rules sit next to the physics:

- **Do not pin the playset to the vault.** The swing set sits on the ten feet of soil, on shallow footings or a pad, the way it would over a buried tank. Do not drive long posts down until they hit the concrete lid. The lid is not a footing.
- **Do not make the dirt do the real work.** Ten feet of cover is the story you tell. The vault still has to meet the lawn number if a flood washes that dirt off.

The playset is allowed because the number on the grass is small, the vault does not depend on the swing set being somewhere else, and the pipe openings are aimed at dirt, not at the slide.

If the top two feet go away

Yards get dug. Yards flood. Two feet of soil can leave.

With ten feet above the lid, two feet gone still leaves eight feet of dirt, plus the whole vault. Losing a couple of feet of soil might make the lawn number a few times higher (dirt cuts dose in layers; take away a layer and more gets through). A few times a number that was already “a few mrem, if anything” is still a small add to background, **if the vault was the real shield**.

If the vault was thin and the dirt was doing the work, two feet gone is a different story. That is why dry soil and a bare lid are design cases, not surprises.

Flood water itself is extra shield. The risk in a flood is **scour**: dirt washed off the lid. The vault should still meet the lawn target with the lid bare, sitting in a washed-out hole. Then a playset after a storm is a mud cleanup. The dose target still holds.

If a machine hits the concrete, that person is on the box, not on the lawn. That contact number is a crew-and-design number. It is not the playset number. A vault built to stand alone stays low there too. A vault that needed the dirt would not.

Soil right against the vault can pick up a little short-lived activity if neutrons leak, which is why the vault's own neutron layer exists. The top two feet of lawn are not that layer. Washing them off does not bring "the hot dirt" to the swing, unless the scour goes all the way to the wall.

What you would measure

On an intact yard, a meter on the grass should read like the rest of the lot, or a faint bump over the lid that is still in the noise of background. Background already wiggles from day to day.

You would not design for a special fence, a keep-off sign, or a rule that the kids play on the other side of the driveway. If those were required, the vault is too thin.

Startup happens after the hole is backfilled and the chase is closed. Until then the core is locked off and is not making this kind of dose. At the end of life the locks go back in before the crane comes. The lawn number is a running, buried number.

What this chapter covered

This is the yard chapter: ten feet of soil above the lid, the vault as the shield, wet dirt better than dry dirt, pipes out the bottom through a buried chase, and a playset as the test. The claim is a few mrem a year extra **if a person lived on the grass**, which is about one cross-country flight; a playset hour a day is a fraction of that flight. Later chapters can put a real shield stack on a drawing. If children cannot play on the grass, the vault is not thick enough.

4. The House

Chapter 3 is the yard. This chapter is how the Backyard Generating Station ties into the panel, the battery, the water heater, and, if you want it, a greenhouse. The vault stays sealed. Everything a plumber or an electrician would recognize happens in a **utility room** at the house end of a buried **chase** (the pipe-and-cable run from the underside of the vault). That room can be in the house or a small shed next to it.

What arrives at the house

Pipes and cables leave through the **bottom** of the vault, bend in the dirt, and come up in the utility room. That is the same idea as a buried propane line or a sewer lateral, with one extra rule: there is no straight shot back to the lid. Chapter 3 explains why. Here, the point is only that people work at the house end, not in the hole.

Figure 3. Heat and power cascade

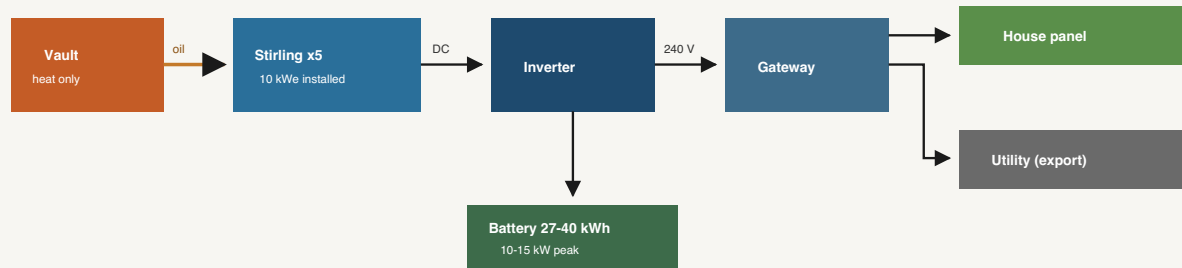
35 kWth in the vault. 8 kWe and 27 kWth out at the utility room. No shaft in the vault.



If the oil pump or Stirling units stop, condenser temperature rises and analog drum springs drive shutdown. Decay heat then goes to the vault mass and earth.

Figure 4. Electrical one-line

Vault is heat-only. Stirling, inverter, gateway, and battery live in the utility room. Gateway required so the house can run when the street is dark.



Without the gateway the inverter trips when the grid dies (anti-islanding). Chapter 1 life-safety case requires the gateway.

Three things come out of that chase:

- **A closed heat loop.** Hot oil (or a similar heat fluid) in a double-wall pipe, cooler fluid back. This is not house water, and it never touches the core.

- **Power cables** from the heat-to-electricity engines in the utility room to an inverter and then to the electrical panel
- **A few status wires** so the inverter and the battery can see that the vault is running

The water in the house never mixes with anything inside the vault. Heat crosses a metal wall in an exchanger, the same way a boiler already hands warmth to a floor loop. If that exchanger ever leaked, you would get a service call in the utility room, not an open vault.

Electricity: panel, inverter, battery

The electrical path is the one a solar-plus-battery job already uses.

There is **no steam turbine** and no spinning plant in the yard. Heat from the vault warms the hot end of a sealed **Stirling** engine in the utility room. A Stirling is a closed box with a hot side and a cool side. The temperature difference moves an internal piston and makes electricity. The same class of machine already runs on wellhead gas and in space tests. Five small units make the house's 8 kW, with a spare. Each is about **12 inches across and 18 inches tall**, about **110 pounds**. Five of them, plus the oil pump and the heat exchanger, sit on a wall or a short rack next to the inverter. They fit a basement utility room or a small shed. They do not fit in a closet. They last on the order of **10 to 15 years** and get swapped in that room, the way a furnace is swapped. They do not live in the vault, because a century-sealed engine inside a buried box has not been

shown. Chapter 2 puts the first set in the install check (**\$40,000 to \$100,000** today, **\$15,000 to \$30,000** as a factory target). The decade swap is a later check. It is not in the simple-payback tables.

The inverter turns that output into ordinary 120/240-volt house current and talks to the utility. When the battery is full and the house is satisfied, it exports. When the house wants more than the battery still holds, it buys a bit from the grid. Chapter 2 is the day-in-the-life. This chapter is the boxes in the utility room.

The battery sits in that room, not in the hole. Two or three wall units in the Tesla-class size (about 13 kWh each) cover the evening spike and a storm night. The vault fills them. They wear out on a decade-scale and get replaced, the same as they would on a solar job. That is owner maintenance. The vault is not.

A backup switch (a gateway) is required if you want the lights on when the street is dark. Ordinary inverters shut off when the grid dies, on purpose, so they do not feed a line a lineman thinks is dead. A gateway isolates the house, then lets the inverter and the battery (and the vault, still making heat) run the panel. Without that box, you have sell-back in good weather and a dark house in a blackout. Chapter 1's life-safety case needs the gateway. Budget it as part of the same electrical job as the inverter.

The utility interconnection is a solar-class permit: an application, a meter that can run both ways, and rules about how much they will buy. The vault does not change that paperwork's shape. It changes how many kilowatt-hours you have to sell.

Heat: use it, or dump it on purpose

Chapter 2 listed what can take the water: radiant floors, a tank, a coil in the air handler, a boiler loop, an air-to-water heat pump, a greenhouse. The house-side hardware is ordinary hot-water heating work.

If the house already has hot-water heat. An isolated exchanger and a pair of pumps (on the house loop, not in the vault) drop in next to the boiler or the manifold. The old boiler stays as backup or peak. The thermostat you already have still calls for heat.

If the house does not. You still get electricity. Showers can take a standalone tank. Whole-house space heat means adding pipes, or sending the loop to a greenhouse, or skipping space heat and using the electricity only.

August. The vault is still making heat while it makes electricity. If the house only wants showers, the rest has to go somewhere on purpose:

- a greenhouse, if you built one
- a small outdoor radiator, the same kind of box a heat pump already uses on the side of a house
- do not leave unused heat to soak into the soil around the vault

If unused heat soaks into the soil, that patch of yard runs warmer. Place the radiator where a condenser already would go. How far the vault sits from the house is a permit question. Those are ordinary siting choices.

Frost on the buried loop is a normal plumbing problem: bury below the frost line, or insulate, or keep a trickle of flow. The chase already runs deep, under the ten feet of cover and over to the house.

Water, flood, and the hole

The vault is built to sit wet. A lot of yards flood in a century. External water is extra shield and extra cooling. The inner vessel stays closed. It is built to live in a wet hole.

The utility-room boxes should sit **above** the flood you actually get, the same as a furnace or a panel should. Where the chase enters the foundation, it gets sealed the way any buried line into a basement gets sealed. Dirt washed off the lid is a Chapter 3 dose case. Water in the basement is a house case. Do not store the battery and the inverter in a pit that fills.

The buried object needs about a **10 by 10 foot** patch of yard. Setbacks from the house, a well, or the property line are the buried-tank kind the town already writes for septic or propane. The drawing says ten feet of soil above the lid. Keep a path a crane can use once at install and once at the swap (Chapter 7).

What the crew does, in order

1. Permits: excavation, electrical, utility interconnection, and plumbing if there is a heat loop. Towns already know most of these as separate stamps.
2. Dig the hole. Bed it. Confirm groundwater and rock before the crane arrives.
3. Set the vault. Do not start it.
4. Run the underside chase to the utility room. Close the trench.
5. Land the Stirling units, inverter, gateway, battery, and (if used) the heat exchanger and radiator.
6. Backfill with **ten feet of soil** above the lid. A playset, if any, sits on that soil, on shallow footings or a pad. It is not bolted to the vault.
7. Inspectors sign the electrical and the burial.
8. A licensed startup (Chapter 5) is the first time the vault makes heat.

A first install on a new house can take days. That is a construction week. The homeowner's job in that list is the same as a solar install plus a buried-tank job: be home for the meter, keep pets away from the work, and decide whether the heat loop is floors, a tank, a greenhouse, or a radiator.

What fails, and what does not

On the house side, the wear items are the Stirling units, the oil pump, the battery, the inverter, a pump on the house heat loop, and the outdoor radiator fan. Those live in the utility room. They are replaceable without opening the vault. A Stirling set or an inverter swap is a decade-class job, in the same cost world as replacing a serious HVAC unit or a home generator, not a new vault. Chapter 2 is the first-set dollar band.

The vault has no owner-service moving parts. Heat inside it moves in sealed **heat pipes** (closed metal tubes, no pump). There is no turbine in the hole. If a heat pipe fails, that tube freezes in place and the others carry the load. If the oil loop in the chase leaks, the leak stays in the trench or the utility room. It does not open the core. If the utility-room engines stop, the vault overheats a little, the control drums spring shut, and leftover heat soaks into the box and the earth.

If the house is sold, the appliance stays with the lot the way a buried tank does, plus the utility-room equipment. Insurance and appraisal will have to treat that package as a normal house feature, the way they learned to treat solar. Until they do, it is a new line on a policy and a new note on an appraisal.

What this chapter covered

This is the house chapter: a buried chase to a utility room, solar-class inverter and sell-back, a gateway so the house can stay on in a blackout, heat the house already uses or a greenhouse or a radiator, and a vault that can sit wet while the batteries stay dry. Chapter 5 is what is inside the vault. Chapter 6 is who lets you set it. The utility-room work should look familiar to a solar electrician or a boiler technician.

5. The Vault

The vault is the sealed box in the hole. Chapter 3 is why the lawn stays a lawn. Chapter 4 is how heat and power leave through the floor. This chapter is what is inside, why it can sit closed for on the order of a century, and why it is furnace-scale rather than a commercial plant.

A 1,000 MW plant is a million kilowatts. This vault makes **5 to 10 kWe** of electricity and about **20 to 40 kW of heat**. That is about **1/100,000 to 1/200,000** the electrical size of the plant people picture. It is furnace scale, not campus scale.

What the box is

From the outside the vault is a lead-lined concrete object about the size of a large septic tank, about eight feet across and eight and a half feet tall, under **ten feet of soil**. A crane can lift it. Nobody on the lot opens it. The lid has no hatch for the owner. Pipes and cables leave through the bottom only, into the buried chase that runs to the utility room.

Inside, in layers:

- **A small core** at the center: a beer-keg-to-dishwasher-sized assembly that holds the fuel
- **A hydrogen-rich and boron-bearing layer** that slows and catches neutrons (the particles that do not care much about lead)

- **Lead and thick concrete** that stop gammas (the hard X-ray-like radiation)
- **The sealed outer vault** the crane sees

The dirt above the lid is extra. The vault is sized to do the stopping on its own, including in dry soil and with the lid bare. Chapter 3 is that argument.

Figure 8. Vault vertical cutaway

2.60 m outer height. Same shield above and below the core. Hopper is last-ditch only (plug 750 C). No owner hatch.

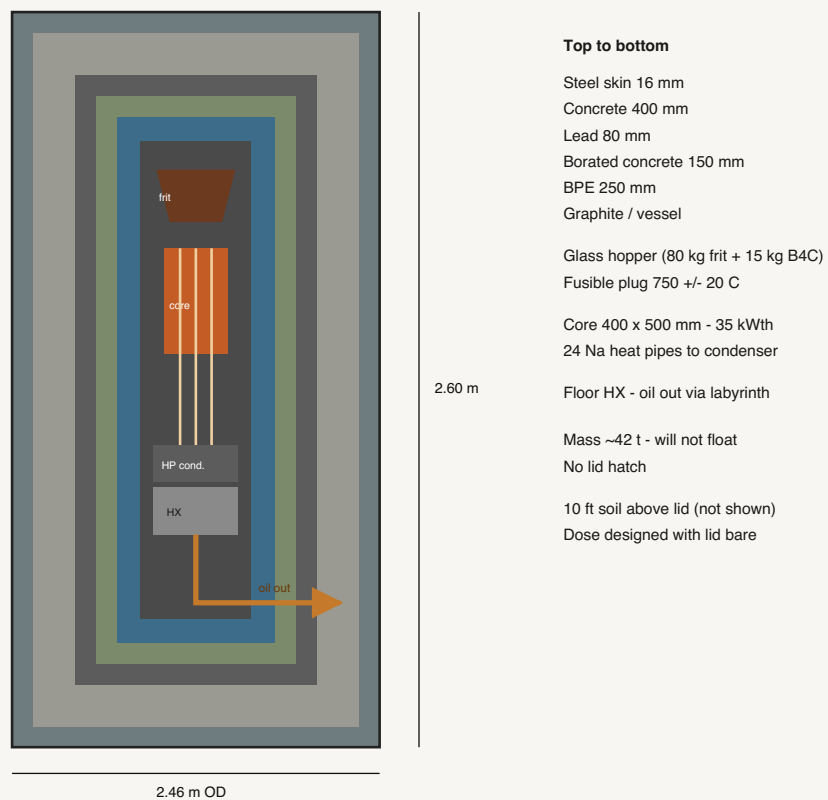
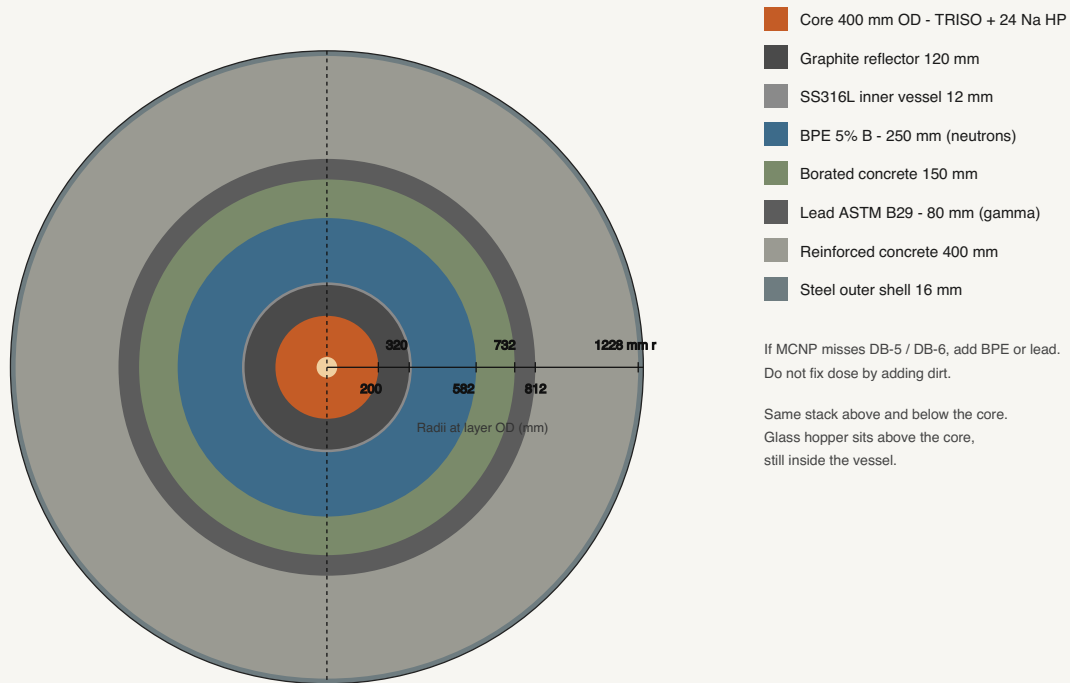


Figure 2. Radial shield stack (half-section, type unit)

Outer diameter 2.46 m. Layers ordered so capture gammas born in BPE hit lead next. Soil is not shown; it is bonus above the lid.



How it makes power

The core is a very small nuclear core. Heat comes from splitting atoms in a sealed fuel, at a scale closer to a large home furnace than to a commercial station.

That kit is not invented here. Coated particle fuel (TRISO), heat pipes, and small Stirling engines have been built and tested for space and shop programs. This product would license that class of hardware, or build it from those proven designs. It is not a space reactor placed in a yard, and it is not a new kind of reaction.

That heat does two jobs at the same time. It becomes electricity for the panel. It is also warmth for floors, showers, or a greenhouse. Using both is the design. If the house or a greenhouse uses the warmth, most of what the core makes is used, not thrown away.

A house-scale electrical output of **5 to 10 kWe** (kilowatts of electricity) goes with about **20 to 40 kW of heat** from the core. That is furnace scale. There is no cooling tower. After shutdown, leftover heat drops to about as much as a small space heater, then lower over hours and days. Dirt, concrete, and time can take that.

From heat in the core to electricity in the house

There is no water flowing through the core, and no steam turbine.

1. **The fuel makes heat.** Tiny coated particles of uranium sit in graphite blocks. About 20% of that uranium is U-235, the isotope that splits easily. The rest is U-238. There are no swimming-pool rods and no open water in the core.
2. **Sealed heat pipes move that heat.** Each pipe is a closed metal tube with a little sodium inside. Sodium is a metal that melts and carries heat very well. When the core is warm, sodium vapor travels to the cool end of the pipe and gives the heat up. It then returns on its own. There is no pump in the vault. The sodium never mixes with house water. If one pipe fails, that tube freezes in place. The others keep working. The core does not “dry out” the way a water reactor can.

3. **A sealed exchanger in the vault floor** hands the heat to a double-wall oil loop. That oil runs through the buried chase to the utility room and back. If the oil leaks, the leak stays in the trench or the utility room. It is a hazardous-fluid cleanup, not an open core.
4. **Stirling engines in the utility room** turn the hot oil and a cool water loop into electricity. A Stirling is a sealed engine with a hot side and a cool side. No flame, no steam, no turbine. Five small units make about 8 kW, with a spare. They last on the order of 10 to 15 years. They live in the utility room on purpose, because a 100-year sealed engine inside the vault has not been shown. Replacing them is a room job, not a yard opening.
5. **Leftover warmth** (about 27 kW on the type unit) goes to house floors, a tank, a greenhouse, or a small outdoor radiator in summer.

If the oil pump or the Stirling units stop, heat has nowhere to go except the vault and the dirt. Temperature at the heat-pipe ends rises. Control drums spring shut, without a phone or a motor that has to stay on. Leftover heat then soaks into the 42-ton box and the earth.

The core is run **cold and slow**: a trickle of heat in a lot of mass. That is how a sealed life on the order of a century is even thinkable. The neutron battering that ages metal in a big plant is much gentler here because the power in each liter of core is small.

The paint-can of fuel

Fuel use at this output, over a century, is measured in kilograms, not tons. Chapter 8 works the inventory: about **30 kilograms (about 66 pounds) at first start**, still a paint-can of heavy metal inside the core, inside the vault. By the end of life, on the order of **15 to 25 kilograms has been used up**. The vault is almost all shield and box. The crane is for the box.

Material mixed into the fuel is used up as the fuel is used up, so the output stays even. There is no refueling truck. There is no hatch. At the end, what cannot be recycled is still in that paint-can size class at a licensed site (Chapter 7).

The fuel is assembled in the factory, in a shutdown state, and never handled on the lot.

Why it stays put

A commercial plant needs staff, pumps, and a tower because leftover heat after shutdown is enormous. Here leftover heat is a space heater. The earth is the sink. The vault does not rely on a pump staying on.

If power is pulled faster or slower, the battery and the inverter in the utility room take the jump. The core is not asked to follow the dryer. It makes a steady trickle.

If the core ever tries to run away (a sudden rise in splitting), the fuel and the geometry are chosen so heat itself slows the reaction: hotter means less splitting, in milliseconds, without a person or a

motor. That is a materials fact, not a software mode. That passive slowing is the ordinary protection. It is why the last-ditch glass layer below is not expected to run.

If the vault ever got far hotter than it should anyway, a passive layer above the core is meant to melt, flow, and set into a glass-like mass that stills the reaction and locks the insides in place. The whole vault stays one object. That is last-ditch only. The fuel and the drums are designed so the vault does not get there.

Off on the truck, on in the hole

Fresh fuel has never been used, so it is not already hot. In the factory the core is assembled with **locks and control elements in the shutdown position**. The vault is sealed around that. What leaves the plant is a heavy, closed object that is not producing electricity and not producing heat.

It is trucked as permitted heavy freight. A crane sets it. Chapter 4's crew connects the utility room. Inspectors sign.

Only after it is buried and the chase is closed does a **licensed startup** happen. The shutdown locks are released in a controlled procedure. That is the first time the core makes heat. Until that step the vault is cold. At the end of life the same locks go back in before the crane returns. The vault that rides out is shut down on purpose, the same way it rode in.

The owner does not hold the key to those locks. A phone app, if there is one, does not move them. Chapter 2's app is a status screen only.

What the vault is not

There is no cooling tower, no staff gate, and no refueling floor.

The owner does not open it to service it. There is no filter, hatch, or oil change in the yard.

It is not safe because the dirt is deep. It is safe because the box is thick, the pipes leave through the floor, the power is furnace-scale, and the locks stay in until a licensed person releases them. Ten feet of soil is the yard you see. The vault still has to meet the lawn dose target if that soil leaves.

It is a 20 to 40 kW heat source in a factory-sealed vault, about 1/100,000 the electrical size of a 1,000 MW plant. That size is the approval argument (Chapter 6).

What this chapter covered

This is the vault: layers, furnace-scale heat, two products (electricity and warmth), heat pipes to an oil chase to Stirling engines in the utility room, a paint-can of fuel, no pumps you service in the yard, a glass dump that is not expected to run, and a truck that carries a locked box. Chapter 3 is the grass. Chapter 4 is the utility room. Chapter 6 is the stamp. The machine is designed so the yard never needs a hatch.

6. The Approval

No regulator has issued this approval yet. This chapter is the path.

The aim is not to site a 1,000 MW campus behind a house. The aim is to treat a factory-sealed, never-opened, furnace-scale vault as a **manufactured appliance**: built in one place, hauled as a closed object, set by licensed people, started by licensed people, and taken back by licensed people. The homeowner owns the appliance. They do not become a plant operator.

Why size is the argument

A typical commercial generating station is about **1,000 MW**. That is a million kilowatts, a staff, a perimeter, and a town-scale fight.

The Backyard Generating Station makes **5 to 10 kWe** and about **20 to 40 kW of heat**. That heat number is a large home furnace. After shutdown, leftover heat is a small space heater. Next to the 1,000 MW plant, this unit is about **1/100,000 to 1/200,000** the electrical size. Chapter 5 is the physics. The approval claim follows from it:

- The object is too small for leftover heat to run away into the neighborhood.
- It ships and sits as one sealed vault. Nobody on the lot opens it.
- The lawn target is a few mrem a year extra, if anything, including with the lid bare (Chapter 3).

- Install looks like a buried tank plus a solar interconnect (Chapter 4).

A rulebook written for a commercial plant will block a house product even when the physics is friendly. The project's plan is a **size-based approval or exemption**: one certified design, made in a factory, installed many times, rather than a custom power-plant license on every lot.

That approval does not exist yet.

Permits towns already know how to issue

Towns already permit:

- a buried concrete tank (septic, propane vault)
- a solar inverter, a battery, and a two-way meter
- a boiler-room heat exchanger
- heavy freight and a crane in a driveway

The federal piece that does not yet exist is permission for the sealed core inside the vault to be that small, that closed, and that numerous. The closest existing ideas are sealed sources and factory-built packages that move as a unit and come back as a unit. The Backyard Generating Station is asking to be closer to those than to a site-built plant.

The homeowner's permits stay local and familiar: dig, set, interconnect, plumb. How far the **10 by 10 foot** patch sits from the house is that local buried-tank conversation. The core never becomes a backyard license.

Who does what

Who	What they do	What they do not do
Factory	Builds, fuels in a shutdown state, seals, ships one design	Does not open it on the lot
Licensed hauler	Moves a closed, locked vault	Does not start it
Licensed set crew	Digs, cranes, chase, backfill	Does not run the core
Licensed startup	Releases shutdown locks after burial and inspection	Does not hand the owner a key to those locks
Electrician / plumber	Utility room: Stirling, inverter, gateway, battery, heat loop	Do not enter the vault
Utility	Interconnect and sell-back rules	Does not own the vault
Homeowner	Thermostat, bill, optional status screen	Does not operate, refuel, or open
Licensed take-back (Chapter 7)	Locks in, crane out, process	Does not leave parts in the shed

If any of those rows becomes a homeowner weekend job, the product is wrong. The core is never a backyard task.

What the exemption is asking

In plain language, the paper would say:

1. This is one manufactured design, not a custom plant.
2. Thermal power is furnace-scale (tens of kW, not thousands of MW), about 1/100,000 the electrical size of a 1,000 MW plant.
3. The vault is sealed at the factory and opened only at a licensed facility at the end.
4. Transport, set, startup, and take-back are licensed steps.
5. Public dose at the grass is designed to a few mrem a year, with the vault alone as the shield.
6. The owner cannot start, stop the core, or move fuel.
7. A failed unit is a crane event, not a local teardown.

Call that an exemption, a general license, or a product certificate. The name matters less than the shape: **approve the object once, install it many times**, the way a listed inverter is listed once and hung in a thousand garages.

Until that exists, every early unit is a special case and will cost like one. Chapter 2's early-production band is that fact in dollars.

What sits next to the stamp

Utility interconnection is a separate yes. A house that can export 35,000 to 59,000 kWh a year will hit sell-back caps and rate design. That is a price-and-tariff issue. It is separate from approval of the core. Chapter 2 already says payback depends on what the utility pays for extra power.

A federal credit like solar's is a separate yes. Solar's early years used a large investment tax credit. The public case here is carbon-free power at the house, fewer 1,000 MW plants towns refuse, and generation that still works at night. It is a policy path, not a promise.

Insurance, appraisal, and resale will lag, the way they lagged for rooftop solar. Until this is common, a buried vault plus a utility room will be a new line on a homeowners policy and a new note on an appraisal.

Town politics will take time. Chapter 3's playset number has to be true and measurable. If the yard needed a keep-off fence, the vault would have failed its own dose target.

What this chapter covered

This is the approval chapter: size as the argument, a factory-sealed appliance rather than a commercial plant, licensed hands at every step that touches the core, and a first stamp that does not exist yet. Chapter 5 is why the size claim is honest. Chapter 7 is the take-back that makes “never opened on the lot” true at the end. The paperwork should look like approving a manufactured appliance, not siting a power plant.

7. The Swap

Nothing is opened in the yard. Replacement means the old vault leaves as one piece and a new one sits in the same hole. The price of that leaving is part of the replacement, not a bill the household discovers decades later.

The day it comes out

On a house that already has a station, the house stays on the **utility** while the crew digs. Digging can take a day or two. The lights stay on. That is not the dark window.

A licensed crew then isolates the station from the house: gateway open, heat loop stopped, inverter off. They put the **shutdown locks back in** the same way Chapter 5 put them in at the factory. The vault stops making heat on purpose. Leftover heat is already small. They wait the hours it takes for that to fall further if the procedure says to wait.

Then a crane lifts the vault, still sealed, onto a permitted truck. The hole that is left is a known shape. The next vault, locked and cold, goes in. Chapter 4's chase lands again in the utility room. Inspectors sign. A licensed startup is the first heat from the new unit.

The homeowner is without the station, and without house power only if the crew has to open the panel, for the **hours** of that lock, lift, set, and reconnect. The wall battery can cover part of that window. A first install on a new house can take days. That is a construction week. The house can stay on the utility while the crew works.

The homeowner does not store, cut, or dispose of anything. There is no pile of old parts by the garage. The core leaves with the vault, on that same truck.

If a unit is swapped early (damage, a recall, a sale that wants a newer vault), the day looks the same. Early or late, it is a crane event.

What happens to the old vault

The truck goes to a licensed facility, not to the town dump.

The box. Lead, steel, and concrete are recycled or reused where that is possible. The vault was almost all shield and box. That mass is ordinary industrial material once it is clean enough for the facility's rules.

The fuel. The work began as about **30 kilograms (66 pounds) at first start** (Chapter 8). After a century, what cannot be recycled or reused is still in that size class. It goes into a paint-can receptacle at a licensed site. It does not stay on the property or in the hole.

The owner never takes title to a waste drum. Take-back is the factory's (or the licensed operator's) job, paid as part of the swap.

What the check includes

A replacement is sold as a **swap**:

- new vault
- removal of the old one
- haul
- processing (recycle what you can, receptacle for what you cannot)
- reconnect of power and heat in the utility room
- licensed shutdown and licensed startup

It should not be a surprise line item after someone has lived with the appliance for decades.

How that is paid can be any of these, or a mix:

- **Prepaid at first install.** A take-back fee sits in the original price, like a deposit on a tank.
- **Included core-exchange.** The company that sold the vault is on the hook to swap it. The homeowner pays a posted swap price that already assumes take-back.
- **A posted price at the time of swap.** Clear dollars, known in advance as a class of job, not a custom demolition bid.

Which of those wins is a business detail. The rule is the same: **replacement means the old station leaves, and the cost of that leaving is inside the replacement.**

The hole, the crane path, and the chase were supposed to stay usable (Chapter 4). If a later owner built a garage on the lift path, that is their extra bill. The vault is still lifted out as one piece. It is not cut open in the yard.

What is not the swap

Batteries, the inverter, and the Stirling units die on a much shorter clock, often 10 to 15 years. Replacing those is a utility-room job, like solar or a furnace. It is not a crane day and not Chapter 7.

The outdoor radiator or a house pump is ordinary hardware. Replacing it is not a vault event.

A playset or a patio on the ten feet of soil is fine if footings stay shallow (Chapter 3). Do not drive long posts into the lid. That makes the later crane lift harder.

The leftover fuel is small, and the process is still specialized. It is not handled like a stack of old solar panels.

A century, or sooner

The vault is designed to run for on the order of a hundred years without a hatch. That is a design life, not a promise that the first owner's great-grandchildren must keep the same serial number. A swap can happen when the unit is done, when a better vault exists, or when the house is reworked.

Until that day, there is no refueling truck and the vault stays sealed. After that day, the story is one lift, one new vault, and leftover fuel in a paint-can-class receptacle at a licensed site.

What this chapter covered

This is the end: locks in, crane out, same hole, recycle the box, leftover fuel to a licensed site, and a replacement price that already includes leaving. An existing house stays on the utility while the crew digs. The dark window, if there is one, is hours. Chapters 3 to 6 are how the yard, the house, the vault, and the stamp make that day ordinary. The household does not keep any part of the old vault.

8. Vault Spec

Document type: Preliminary design basis (not a licensed safety analysis).

Unit: Backyard Generating Station, type **BGS-8**. The 8 is the electrical size (8 kWe), not “the eighth try.” This is the first type unit. Family band is 5 to 10 kWe.

Audience: Mechanical, nuclear, shielding, and electrical engineers. Chapter 5 is the homeowner story. This file is what you size, buy, and analyze.

In one paragraph: a sealed heat source in a septic-tank vault, **3.0 m (10 ft) of soil above the lid**, heat pipes to a double-wall oil chase, electricity made in the **utility room** by replaceable Stirling engines. The vault is the shield. Dirt is bonus. Dose is designed with the lid bare. The core kit (TRISO, heat pipes, drums, Stirling) is a known class of hardware, licensed or built from that class, not a new reaction.

An engineer can use this to start a sign-off package. They cannot stamp the vault from this file alone. Required follow-on work is listed in §16. Numbers below are closed arithmetic or standard handbook values. Where a transport code (**MCNP**, Monte Carlo N-Particle: the standard program that tracks neutrons and gammas through the shield to predict dose), SCALE, or an ASME stress report is mandatory, the spec says so and gives the requirement the code run must meet.

No owner hatch. No in-vault service pumps. Power conversion that wears is on the house side of the chase. The vault is a sealed heat source.

1. Design basis (shall)

ID	Requirement
DB-1	Continuous electrical output 8.0 kWe net at the inverter DC bus, product family 5 to 10 kWe .
DB-2	Core thermal power 35 kWth nominal (32 kWth at 25% conversion plus 10% margin). Family band 20 to 40 kWth.
DB-3	Sealed operating life 100 years at $\geq 90\%$ capacity factor without opening the vault.
DB-4	Heat and electricity are both products. Reject heat from conversion is 80 to 120°F hydronic water (27 to 49°C) for the house, or a greenhouse, or a dedicated dry cooler.
DB-5	Extra dose at the grass, dry soil, vault running: ≤ 5 mrem/year if a person occupied that spot 8,760 h/y. Playset at 1 h/d is then ~ 0.2 mrem/y (Chapter 3).
DB-6	Same 5 mrem/y target with the lid bare (scour / 2 ft of soil gone). Soil is bonus, not the shield.
DB-7	Penetrations floor only , then a bent chase. No lid penetrations.
DB-8	Vault sits flooded . External water is allowed. Inner boundary remains leak-tight.
DB-9	Factory assembled subcritical, shutdown locks in . First heat only after burial and licensed startup. Locks in before crane-out.
DB-10	No vault-side pump required for core cooling or shutdown decay heat.
DB-11	Excess reactivity after shutdown margin shall be $< 0.8\%$ so a single failure cannot make the core prompt-critical.
DB-12	Last-ditch borosilicate + B ₄ C dump, fusible, no power required. Not credited for normal operation.
DB-13	All in-vault materials are items a US nuclear or ASME shop can buy or already fabricates. No exotic materials.

2. Power and energy (closed arithmetic)

2.1 Why 35 kWth

House-side conversion baseline is free-piston Stirling, $\eta = 0.25$ (hot end ~ 350 to 600°C , cold end ~ 40 to 50°C). Demonstrated class: NASA KRUSTY / Sunpower-style convertors; commercial wellhead units (Qnergy class) exist at several kWe.

$$\begin{aligned} P_{\text{th}} &= P_{\text{e}} / \eta = 8.0 \text{ kWe} / 0.25 = 32.0 \text{ kWth} \\ P_{\text{th,spec}} &= 32.0 \times 1.10 = 35.2 \text{ kWth} \rightarrow \text{specify } 35 \text{ kWth} \\ P_{\text{reject}} &= 35 - 8 = 27 \text{ kWth} \end{aligned}$$

27 kWth is a mid-size house heating load (typical winter 5 to 15 kW) plus domestic hot water, with margin, or a greenhouse, or a ~ 10 -ton-class dry cooler in summer (1 refrigeration ton ≈ 3.5 kW).

If conversion is only thermoelectric at $\eta = 0.08$, the same 8 kWe needs **100 kWth**. That is a different, larger vault. It is the alternate in §6.3. Baseline is 35 kWth.

2.2 Annual electricity

$$\begin{aligned} 8.0 \text{ kW} \times 8,760 \text{ h/y} &= 70,080 \text{ kWh/y} \\ \text{at } 90\% \text{ CF: } 8.0 \times 8,760 \times 0.90 &= 63,072 \text{ kWh/y} \end{aligned}$$

Typical house 11,000 kWh/y $\rightarrow$ export $\sim 52,000$ to $59,000$ kWh/y.
High-use house 25,000 to 35,000 kWh/y $\rightarrow$ export $\sim 28,000$ to $45,000$ kWh/y.

Average house load 1.1 to 4 kW. 8 kWe covers both. Peaks 10 to 20 kW are the battery (Chapter 4).

2.3 100-year thermal energy and burnup

$$E = 35 \text{ kW} \times 8,760 \text{ h/y} \times 100 \text{ y} = 30,660,000 \text{ kWh}$$

$$= 30,660 \text{ MWh}$$

$$P = 0.035 \text{ MW}$$

$$E = 0.035 \text{ MW} \times 365.25 \text{ d/y} \times 100 \text{ y} = 1,278.4 \text{ MWd}$$

Heavy-metal mass from burnup B (MWd per tonne):

$$m_{\text{burned}} (\text{t}) = 1,278.4 / B$$

Assumed discharge burnup	Burned HM	Notes
50 GWd/t (50,000 MWd/t)	25.6 kg	Conservative UO ₂ -class
80 GWd/t	16.0 kg	TRISO-UCO, realistic target
100 GWd/t	12.8 kg	Aggressive TRISO

Inventory at first start is larger than mass consumed (need leftover fissile at year 100, burnable poison, and a critical geometry). Specify:

Item	Value
Heavy metal at first start	30 kg (66 lb)
Consumed HM at 80 GWd/t, end of life	16 kg (35 lb)
Residual HM at end of life	~14 kg in the same compacts

Layman Chapter 5's older “~10 kg” was order-of-magnitude at a lower thermal power. This spec supersedes it for engineering.

2.4 Fission rate and U-235 consumed

Energy per fission: $200 \text{ MeV} = 200 \times 1.602 \times 10^{-13} \text{ J} = \mathbf{3.204 \times 10^{-11} \text{ J}}$.

$$R_f = 35,000 \text{ J/s} / 3.204 \times 10^{-11} \text{ J} = 1.092 \times 10^{15} \text{ fissions/s}$$

Per year (365.25 d):

$$\begin{aligned} N_y &= 1.092 \times 10^{15} \times 3.15576 \times 10^7 = 3.447 \times 10^{22} \text{ fissions/y} \\ m_{\text{U235}} &= 3.447 \times 10^{22} / 6.022 \times 10^{23} \times 235 \text{ g} = 13.45 \text{ g/y} \\ 100 \text{ y} &\rightarrow 1.35 \text{ kg U-235-equivalent fissioned} \end{aligned}$$

Some fissions at mid-life are Pu-239. The 1.35 kg is fission-equivalent, not a claim that only U-235 fissions.

Initial U-235 in 30 kg of 19.75 wt% U:

$$0.1975 \times 30 \text{ kg} = 5.93 \text{ kg U-235}$$

Burning 1.35 kg-eq leaves several kg fissile plus bred Pu. End-of-life criticality is a SCALE/ORIGEN depletion problem (§16). It is not a fuel-shortage problem.

2.5 Decay heat (shutdown)

Way / ANS-style: $P/P_0 \approx 0.066 t^{-0.2}$ (t in seconds, infinite prior operation, good enough for sizing).

Time after shutdown	t (s)	$t^{-0.2}$	P/P_0	P (kW)	Household analog
1 s	1	1.000	0.066	2.31	Large space heater
1 h	3,600	0.194	0.0128	0.45	Small space heater
1 d	86,400	0.103	0.0068	0.24	Heat lamp
7 d	6.05×10^5	0.0697	0.0046	0.16	Night-light class, thermal

DB-10 is satisfied: after trip, the vault mass (~42 t, §9) and earth reject <1 kW without a pump. No tower.

Crude earth conduction, treat vault as a sphere $r = 1.4$ m, soil $k = 1.0$ W/m·K, $Q = 0.5$ kW:

$$\Delta T = Q / (4 \pi k r) = 500 / (4 \times 3.1416 \times 1.0 \times 1.4) = 28 \text{ K}$$

Soil far-field plus 28°C at the wall after a few hours. Acceptable. **Do not use this formula for operating 35 kW.** Operating heat is extracted by heat pipes. If 35 kW were dumped to soil: $\Delta T \approx 1,990$ K, which is why August heat must go to a dry cooler or a greenhouse (Chapter 4), not into the dirt.

3. Core

In plain language: the core is a beer-keg-sized graphite block full of coated uranium particles (TRISO), not a pool of water and not a bundle of bare rods. About 20% of the uranium is U-235. Sodium sits only inside sealed heat pipes. There is no water in the core and nothing that can “boil dry.” Heat pipes fail by freezing in place. Heritage is Kilopower / KRUSTY and eVinci-class hardware, scaled to house power, not a new reaction.

3.1 Type (baseline)

Heat-pipe microreactor, TRISO-UCO fuel, graphite moderator/reflector, sodium heat pipes.

Heritage: NASA KRUSTY (heat pipes + Stirling), Westinghouse eVinci (heat-pipe microreactor), X-energy / BWXT TRISO. All components exist in some form. This product would license or build

from that class. This unit is smaller than eVinci (that is MWt-class) and longer-lived than KRUSTY (that was a short ground test). It is built from that class of hardware, not a copy of either machine.

Why TRISO, not UZrH, as baseline: TRIGA UZrH has a stronger prompt negative coefficient (good). Hydrogen migration and hydride stability over 100 years are not a signed-off materials program. TRISO-UCO in graphite is the US path that already has a fuel fabrication line. Prompt feedback is Doppler in the kernel (negative, weaker than UZrH). Safety then also depends on **DB-11** (little excess reactivity) plus the glass dump.

Alternate (if a materials program qualifies it): UZrH-LEU 19.75% rods, TRIGA geometry. Same vault, different core cartridge. Note as Option C-2, not baseline.

3.2 Fuel specification

Parameter	Spec	Why it is buyable
Kernel	UCO, 19.75 ± 0.20 wt% U-235	Standard US research / HALEU assay. Not HEU.
Particle	TRISO: IPyC / SiC / OPyC on kernel	BWXT / X-energy class process
Compact	Cylindrical graphite compact, TRISO packed ~35 vol%	Prismatic microreactor practice
HM at first start	30 kg (66 lb)	\$2.3
Burnable poison	Er_2O_3 or Gd_2O_3 integral in compact or as discrete rods	Standard PWR/microreactor practice
Design burnup	80 GWd/t peak compact, 100 GWd/t not required	TRISO has been taken past this in AGR/HTGR tests
Fission-gas	Held in TRISO buffer; no vented fuel	Required for a sealed vault

Enrichment stays **below 20%** so the material is HALEU, not HEU. That is a security and policy choice as well as a physics choice.

3.3 Geometry (type unit)

Active core: 400 mm diameter × 500 mm height
 Core volume: $\pi \times 0.20^2 \times 0.50 = 0.0628 \text{ m}^3 = 62.8 \text{ L}$
 Power density: $35 \text{ kW} / 62.8 \text{ L} = 0.56 \text{ kW/L} = 0.56 \text{ MW/m}^3$

A PWR is $\sim 100 \text{ MW/m}^3$. This core is $\sim 200\times$ less dense. That is the 100-year fluence trick.

HM loading: $30 \text{ kg} / 62.8 \text{ L} = 0.48 \text{ g/cm}^3$

TRISO compacts routinely hold 0.5 to 1.0 g/cm³ HM. 0.48 is not cramped.

Heat-pipe lattice (plan): 24 sodium heat pipes, 22 mm OD, on a triangular pitch through the graphite, plus ~80 to 120 fuel compact channels. Exact lattice is an MCNP/SCALE item. Pipe count from §4.1.

Reflector: 120 mm radial and axial graphite (or BeO if a later run needs a smaller core; graphite is cheaper and fully supply-chain). Outer reflector diameter $400 + 2 \times 120 = \mathbf{640 \text{ mm}}$. Beer-keg to dishwasher, as Chapter 5 said.

Inner vessel: SS316L, 12 mm wall, ~700 mm OD, helium or low-pressure inert fill around the graphite. Not a PWR pressure boundary. Design pressure $\leq \mathbf{0.5 \text{ MPa}}$ (gas plus heat-pipe fail-in-place). ASME VIII or III as the QA program dictates.

3.4 Neutronics requirements (analysis, not a fake k_{eff})

The following are acceptance criteria for the lattice model. Do not invent a k_{eff} in this file.

State	Criterion
Cold, clean, drums in (factory / truck)	$k_{eff} \leq 0.95$, including 3σ and tolerances
Hot, xenon eq., drums at power, BOL	$1.000 \leq k_{eff} \leq 1.005$, drums not on a stop
Hot, EOL, poisons depleted	$k_{eff} \geq 1.000$ with drums at max worth remaining
Most reactive drum stuck out, others in	$k_{eff} \leq 0.99$
All drums out, cold, clean (beyond design)	Still < prompt critical; DB-11
Flooded inner vessel (water ingress)	k_{eff} decreases or stays subcritical (void / spectrum shall be analyzed both ways)

Drum / rod worth: **B₄C control drums** in the reflector (eVinci / Kilopower style), 6 drums. Shutdown margin $\geq 1.0\%$ with most reactive drum stuck withdrawn. Mechanical locks pin drums in the in (absorbing) position for transport. Licensed startup is a keyed, two-person rotation to the operating arc. The owner key does not exist.

Burnable poison designed so drum motion over 100 years is slow (a few degrees per decade), not weekly.

3.5 Fluence (order of magnitude)

Fission density:

$$1.092 \times 10^{15} \text{ /s} \quad / \quad 6.28 \times 10^4 \text{ cm}^3 = 1.74 \times 10^{10} \text{ fissions/cm}^3 \cdot \text{s}$$

If macroscopic fission cross section $\Sigma_f \sim 0.08$ to 0.15 cm^{-1} (to be taken from the lattice), thermal flux is:

$$\phi \sim (1.74 \times 10^{10}) / \Sigma_f \approx 1 \times 10^{11} \text{ to } 2 \times 10^{11} \text{ n/cm}^2 \cdot \text{s}$$

$$t_{100y} = 3.15576 \times 10^9 \text{ s}$$

$$\Phi \sim 3 \times 10^{20} \text{ to } 7 \times 10^{20} \text{ n/cm}^2$$

That is research-reactor cladding fluence, not a 40-year PWR barrel. SS316L, graphite, and TRISO SiC are in a plausible range. **dpa and graphite shrinkage still need a materials assessment** (§16). This is why power density was kept low on purpose.

4. Heat transport (in the vault: no pumps)

In plain language: sodium stays inside 24 sealed heat pipes. Those pipes hand heat to a sealed exchanger in the vault floor. Double-wall oil carries that heat through the buried chase to the utility room. House water never enters the vault. An oil leak is a trench or room cleanup. A sodium leak stays in that pipe and freezes. If the utility-room engines stop, drums spring in and leftover heat goes to the 42 t box and the earth.

4.1 Sodium heat pipes

Parameter	Spec
Working fluid	Sodium, ASTM / nuclear grade
Count	24 operating + 4 spare channels (plugged spares)
Rating	1.6 kW each at 600°C vapor
24 × 1.6	38.4 kW > 35 kW _{th}
Envelope	SS316L or Haynes 230, 22 mm OD, ~1.8 m long
Wick	Sintered or annular-gap, space/heat-pipe vendor practice (ACT, Thermacore class)
Freeze	Na melts at 98°C. Startup from a cold truck uses trace heaters on the condenser block (powered from the house during licensed startup only) or a NaK subset (3 pipes) that are liquid at room temp to bootstrap
Fail-in-place	One pipe fail: $23 \times 1.6 = 36.8$ kW, still above 35. Two fail: 35.2 kW. Three fail: derate electrical output.

Kilopower/KRUSTY ran sodium heat pipes on a real critical core. This is the most manufacturable high-T, no-pump choice.

4.2 Temperature cascade (CHP)

Heat steps down, on purpose, from the fuel to the house. Each row is cooler than the one above it.

Where	About how hot	Why
Fuel compact	650 to 750°C	TRISO ceramic is fine well above this
Heat-pipe vapor	~600°C	Sodium vapor inside the sealed pipes
Primary exchanger	~550°C metal	Vault floor, still inside the box
Oil loop in the chase	~350°C	Double-wall; or 500°C if a later NaK loop
Stirling hot end (utility room)	300 to 500°C	Replaceable engines, not in the vault
Stirling cool end	40 to 50°C water	The leftover heat product
House heat loop	80 to 120°F (27 to 49°C)	After a mixing valve, floor and tank range

A perfect heat engine between those Stirling temperatures (about 600 K hot, 320 K cold) could turn at most about 47% of the heat into electricity. That ceiling is called Carnot. A real Stirling at 25% is about half of that ceiling. That is a normal real engine, not a calculation error.

4.3 Secondary loop (vault floor → chase → house)

Baseline fluid: Dowtherm A or equivalent, double-wall, leak-detected annulus, buried. Max bulk 350°C, well inside the oil's 400°C rating. Industrial solar-thermal / process shops already weld this.

$$\begin{aligned}
 Q &= 35 \text{ kW} \\
 c_p &\approx 2.2 \text{ kJ/kg} \cdot \text{K} \\
 \Delta T &= 40 \text{ K} \\
 m &= Q / (c_p \Delta T) = 35 / (2.2 \times 40) = 0.40 \text{ kg/s} \approx 6 \text{ to } 7 \text{ gpm}
 \end{aligned}$$

Pipe: 25 mm (1 in) inner process + 40 mm containment. Two pipes (hot/return) in the chase. Circulation pump is **in the utility room**, not in the vault. Vault-side flow through the primary HX is driven by the heat pipes (vapor to condenser). The oil loop can sit still during shutdown; decay heat does not need it.

Primary HX: printed-circuit or helical-coil SS316L, bolted in a sealed floor compartment of the vault, welded closed at the factory. Oil in, oil out, through the floor only.

Leak: oil stays in the chase / house. It never becomes a core LOCA. Na stays in the heat pipes. A pipe fail freezes sodium in place.

Alternate secondary: NaK (liquid at room temp, better heat transfer, water-reactive). Only if the oil loop's 350°C cap hurts Stirling efficiency. Then an extra isolation HX before any water.

4.4 House reject and summer

27 kWth to:

- hydronic HX (plate, stainless, isolated from potable), or
- greenhouse loop, or
- dry cooler: **27 kW** air coil, ~10-ton HVAC condenser class, COTS (Modine / Guntner / any chiller reject).

If the oil pump stops and Stirlings stop, 35 kW has nowhere to go except the vault and soil. **Overtemp on the condenser block rotates drums in** (analog, spring or gravity, two channels). Core goes to decay heat. That is the protected fault for “utility room offline.”

5. Power conversion (utility room, replaceable)

In plain language: the vault is a sealed heater. Electricity is made in the utility room. A 100-year sealed Stirling inside the vault is not a demonstrated part. Demonstrated engine life is a decade, not a century. So the engines sit where a furnace sits, and they get swapped there.

The vault has no shaft. Conversion is Chapter 4 equipment.

Item	Spec
Convertors	5 × 2.0 kWe hermetic free-piston Stirling (10 kWe installed)
Envelope	~300 mm OD × 450 mm H, ~50 kg each (Microgen 1–2 kWe class). Five plus oil HX and pump fit a utility room, not a closet.
First-cost class	\$8k to \$20k per unit today; \$3k to \$6k factory target. Set: \$40k to \$100k today, \$15k to \$30k factory (Chapter 2).
Dispatch	4 of 5 for 8 kWe; 1 spare online or rotating
Life	10 to 15 years each; swap on the wall, vault stays closed. Decade swap is not in Chapter 2 simple payback.
Output	200 to 400 VDC → hybrid inverter (IEEE 1547 / UL 1741)
Gateway	Required for islanding (Chapter 4). Without it the house goes dark when the utility does.
Battery	2 to 3 × 13.5 kWh (27 to 40 kWh), 10 to 15 kW peak

Alternate 6.3, no moving parts: utility room is a thermoelectric array. $\eta \approx 0.08 \rightarrow$ core must be **100 kWth**, fuel and shield grow (~2.9× burnup, larger vault). Use only if a customer forbids a Stirling set.

6. Shielding and dose

In plain language: the vault, not the dirt, is the shield. Ten feet of soil is the yard you see and extra attenuation. The live-on-the-grass number (≤ 5 mrem/y) must still hold with the lid bare and the soil dry. A playset at one hour a day is then about 0.2 mrem/y. MCNP (defined in the header) has to confirm the stack. Until that run exists, 5 mrem/y is a requirement, not a measured result.

6.1 Sources (running, 35 kWth)

Neutrons: $\sim 2.4 \text{ n/fission} \times 1.092 \times 10^{15} = 2.62 \times 10^{15} \text{ n/s}$

Gamma energy (prompt $\sim 7 \text{ MeV/fission}$):

$$7 \times 10^6 \times 1.602 \times 10^{-19} \times 1.092 \times 10^{15} = 1.22 \text{ kW gamma}$$

Plus capture gammas in the shield (especially 2.2 MeV from H, and Fe if any). Capture gamma is why lead sits **outside** the hydrogenous layer.

Unshielded neutron flux at 2 m:

$$\Phi = S / (4 \pi r^2) = 2.62 \times 10^{15} / (4 \pi \times 4 \times 10^4 \text{ cm}^2) = 5.2 \times 10^9 \text{ n/cm}^2 \cdot \text{s}$$

That is immediately unsurvivable. The shield is not optional.

6.2 Target dose rates

Location	Running	Shutdown (1 d)
Grass, 3.0 m (10 ft) soil above lid, dry soil	$\leq 0.57 \mu\text{rem/h}$ ($\rightarrow 5 \text{ mrem}/8,760 \text{ h}$)	$\ll$ running
Lid outer surface, no soil (scour)	$\leq 0.57 \mu\text{rem/h}$	same target
Side of buried vault, in soil, 1 m from wall	$\leq 5 \mu\text{rem/h}$ (occupational not applicable; this is dirt)	—
House chase, after two bends	$\leq 50 \mu\text{rem/h}$ contact on the pipe chase (worker, short time)	—

0.57 $\mu\text{rem/h}$ is ~5% of a typical 10 $\mu\text{R/h}$ backyard background. A meter may not see it.

6.3 Layer stack (radial, type unit)

Inside to outside:

Layer	Thickness	Outer diameter	Function
Core	200 mm radius	400 mm	Fuel + heat pipes
Graphite reflector	120 mm	640 mm	Neutrons back, some shield
SS inner vessel	12 mm	664 mm	Seal, not the gamma wall
Borated polyethylene (BPE, 5 wt% B)	250 mm	1,164 mm	Slow and eat neutrons
Borated concrete (2 wt% B)	150 mm	1,464 mm	Neutrons + some gamma
Lead (ASTM B29)	80 mm	1,624 mm	Gamma, including capture
Reinforced concrete	400 mm	2,424 mm	Gamma, structure, missile
Steel outer shell	16 mm	2,456 mm	Skin, lift lugs, waterproof

Outer diameter $\approx$ 2.46 m (8.1 ft). Outer height $\approx$ 2.60 m (8.5 ft).

Large septic / small cask. Not a campus.

Axial: same water-equivalent above and below the core, plus a 250 mm glass-dump hopper **above** the core, still inside the vessel, still under the top shield. Floor chase leaves through the bottom biological shield in an offset steel labyrinth (two 90° turns, 200 mm BPE lining).

6.4 Attenuation (handbook, not a substitute for MCNP)

Tenth-value layers (TVL), approximate, fission spectrum / ~1 to 2 MeV gamma:

Material	TVL neutrons (fission)	TVL gamma (~1.5 MeV)
BPE	~12 to 15 cm	poor (use lead)
Concrete	~20 to 28 cm	~20 to 24 cm
Lead	poor	~4.0 to 4.5 cm
Dry soil	worse than wet by ~1.5 to 2× for n	~25 to 35 cm
Wet soil	closer to concrete for n	~20 to 30 cm

Neutron path (radial): 25 cm BPE (~1.8 TVL) + 15 cm borated concrete (~0.6 TVL) + 40 cm concrete (~1.6 TVL) $\approx$ **4 TVL $\approx 10^4$** before soil. Dry-soil bonus is then extra. **Not enough alone** for 10^8 to 10^9 . The reflector, BPE boron capture, and the fact that the core is small ($1/r^2$ and self-shielding) have to be in the transport model.

Preliminary stack is sized to give MCNP a geometry that can meet DB-5 and DB-6. If it misses, add BPE or lead, do not add “more dirt” as the fix.

Gamma path: 8 cm lead $\approx$ 1.8 TVL (×63) plus 40 cm concrete $\approx$ 1.8 TVL (×63) $\approx$ **×4,000** plus soil. Capture gammas born in the BPE are what the lead is for. Order the layers as drawn. Do not put lead inside the BPE.

Sign-off run: MCNP6 or equivalent, running and shutdown, dry sand (5 wt% water) and wet (15 wt%), lid buried and lid bare, chase streaming, skyshine with lid bare. Until that run exists, DB-5 is a requirement, not a demonstrated number.

6.5 Playset (from Chapter 3, numbers)

5 mrem/y $\times$ (365 h / 8,760 h) = 0.21 mrem/y at 1 h/d
 Coast-to-coast flight $\approx$ 3 to 5 mrem
 Playset year $\approx$ 1/15 to 1/25 of one flight

7. Passive safety

7.1 Normal

- Low power density, heat pipes, no pump.
- House load steps are the battery. Core is steady.
- Doppler in UCO kernels: negative. Graphite: slight positive moderator temp in some lattices; **the lattice shall be designed so the net power coefficient is negative** from 20°C to 750°C. That is a hard SCALE/MCNP criterion.

7.2 Anticipated faults

Fault	Response
Oil pump off / Stirling off	Condenser T rises. Analog bi-metal or fusible link releases drum springs in . Decay heat to earth.
One or two heat pipes dead	Margin in §4.1.
Grid loss	Gateway islands. Vault does not care.
Chase shear (excavator)	Double-wall oil spill is a hazmat event, not a core event. Drums in on overtemp.
Flood	External water: more shield, more cooling. Inner vessel designed not to flood. If it does, k_{eff} criterion in §3.4.
Dry soil / drought	Shield still meets DB-5 without wet dirt.
Scour to lid	DB-6.

7.3 Glass dump (last ditch, not credited in the licensing basis until tested)

Item	Spec
Mass	80 kg borosilicate frit + 15 kg B ₄ C powder
Hold-up	Hopper above core, 304 SS, fusible plug
Plug	Au-Ge or Al-Si eutectic, melt 750 ± 20°C (above normal HP 600°C, below vessel limits)
Action	Gravity pour into core channels, boron kills reactivity, glass wets and sets
Power	None
Expected use	Once in never. Qualification: furnace test on a dummy lattice.

7.4 Why a “runaway” is not a plant-scale event

Stored energy in 35 kW for 10 s = 350 kJ (one-tenth of a kWh)

A prompt jump that self-limits in milliseconds dumps a small energy into a large graphite/steel mass. There is no 3 GWth inventory. Decay heat is a space heater. That is the size argument in Chapter 6, in numbers.

8. Mechanical envelope, mass, soil, flood

8.1 Mass build (type unit)

Item	Volume or note	Mass
Concrete (shield + structure)	$\sim 10.5 \text{ m}^3 \times 2,400 \text{ kg/m}^3$	25,200 kg
Lead	$\sim 1.05 \text{ m}^3 \times 11,340 \text{ kg/m}^3$	11,900 kg
BPE	$\sim 0.85 \text{ m}^3 \times 940 \text{ kg/m}^3$	800 kg
Steel shells, vessel, lugs	—	2,800 kg
Graphite + TRISO + Na + drums	—	1,400 kg
Total		$\sim 42,100 \text{ kg}$ (92,800 lb, 46.4 short tons)

Lead volume check: cylindrical shell ID 1.464 m, $t = 0.08$ m, $h = 1.80$ m:

$$\begin{aligned} V_{\text{wall}} &= \pi h (R^2 - r^2) = 3.1416 \times 1.80 \times (0.812^2 - 0.732^2) = 0.70 \text{ m}^3 \\ V_{\text{ends}} &\approx 2 \times \pi \times 0.77^2 \times 0.08 = 0.30 \text{ m}^3 \\ V_{\text{Pb}} &\approx 1.00 \text{ m}^3 \quad (\text{table uses } 1.05 \text{ with laps}) \end{aligned}$$

Concrete: outer cylinder 2.42 m OD, 2.60 m tall, minus inner cavity ~1.62 m, plus extra in the floor labyrinth. 10.5 m^3 is a rounded shop number; the civil drawing shall close the takeoff.

8.2 Soil bearing and buoyancy

Footprint $\approx \pi \times 1.23^2 = 4.75 \text{ m}^2$.

$$q = 42,100 \text{ kg} \times 9.81 \text{ N/kg} / 4.75 \text{ m}^2 = 87 \text{ kPa} \approx 1.8 \text{ ksf}$$

Most residential soils are 1.5 to 3 ksf allowable. Spec a **200 mm compacted crushed-stone pad**. If the geotech says no, a thin concrete mat. Not a pile foundation.

Displaced volume $\approx \pi \times 1.23^2 \times 2.60 = 12.3 \text{ m}^3$. Buoyant force in full flood:

$$12.3 \text{ m}^3 \times 1,000 \text{ kg/m}^3 = 12.3 \text{ t} \ll 42 \text{ t}$$

The vault **does not float**. No hold-down straps required for buoyancy. Still grout the pad so it does not walk in a scour hole.

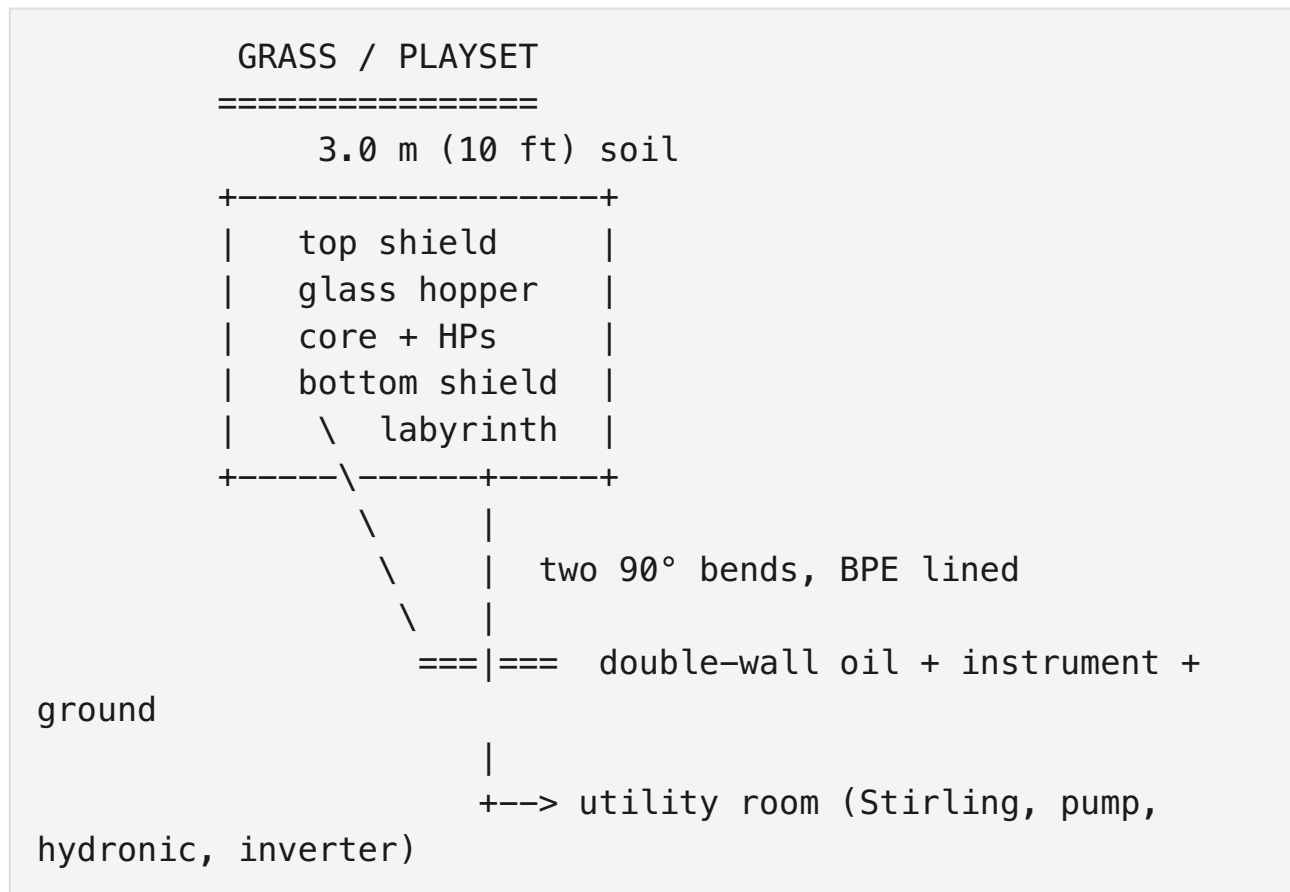
8.3 Lift and transport

- Four trunnions on the steel shell, 2 × 25 t WLL each, redundant pair.
- Highway: overweight / overwidth permit, lowboy. 2.46 m wide is legal in most states with a permit (8.5 ft wide is the usual unpermitted cap; this is ~8.1 ft **body**; add 6 in lugs and you need a permit). Height on a 0.5 m deck ≈ 3.1 m, OK.
- Crane: 80 to 100 t class at 6 to 8 m radius (ordinary house-move / septic crane).
- Package: analyze as a **Type B** transport (10 CFR 71) for the fueled vault. That is a real cost and a real test (drop, fire, immersion). Do not skip it.

8.4 Lid-to-grass

3.0 m (10 ft) of backfill above the lid. Dose still designed to DB-5 / DB-6 with the lid bare. Soil is bonus. Vault height 2.60 m + 3.0 m cover → excavation ~5.6 m (about 18.5 ft) to the pad. That is a deep buried-tank hole, shored, in the same class as a large underground fuel tank or cistern, not a shallow septic lid. Grass footprint of the object is about **10 × 10 ft**. Setbacks from the house are a local buried-tank permit, not this spec.

9. Penetrations and chase



Through the floor only:

- 2 × thermal-oil process + containment
- 1 × instrument bundle (MI cable, Class 1E-equivalent for drum trip)
- 1 × startup heater power (used once, then locked out)
- 1 × ground

No air intake. No stack. No lid penetration. Streaming: each line offset so there is no straight line from the core to the grass.

Acceptance: MCNP chase model $\leq 50 \mu\text{rem/h}$ on the house-end pipe.

Frost: bury below local frost line or heat-trace the oil (oil is already hot when running; shutdown in a Minnesota January needs freeze protection on the oil, pour-point of Dowtherm A is fine, viscosity is the issue). House pump and a small trickle or a tank heater.

10. I&C and states

10.1 States

```
FACTORY_SHUTDOWN → (seal) → TRANSPORT → SET → CONNECT
    → INSPECT → LICENSED_START → RUN → (overtemp |
command)
    → SHUTDOWN → COOL → LICENSED_LOCK → LIFT
```

State	Drums	Heat	Oil pump	Notes
Factory / transport / set	Locked in	0	off	Fresh fuel, no decay heat
Licensed start	Stepped out	rising	on	Trace heat on Na if needed
Run	Fine arc	35 kWth	on	Owner cannot move drums
Shutdown	In	decay	off	Analog trip or licensed
Lift	Locked in	decay only	off	Wait until P_decay < 0.4 kW (~1 d)

10.2 Trip (analog, two channels, no phone)

- Condenser / HP vapor T high
- Drum position disagree

- Seismic switch (optional, cheap)
- Manual licensed trip at the house panel (key, not an app)

App / inverter: status only (Chapter 2). Not a drum control. Not a storm mode.

10.3 Instruments (ex-core)

- 2 × fission chambers or Compensated ion chambers in the reflector (startup + run)
 - 6 × Type K or N thermocouples on heat-pipe condensers
 - Oil T and flow at the HX
 - He / moisture in the inner vessel
 - Lead-door / seal wires (IAEA-style) for tamper
-

11. Environments

Load	Spec
Flood	Full immersion, indefinite. IP68 / submarine weld on outer shell.
Dry sand	Shield analysis at 5 wt% water.
Design soil T	−20 to 40°C far field
Seismic	ASCE 43 or IBC site class D, 0.3 g, vault as a rigid box on a pad. No in-core mechanisms except drums (latched).
Tornado / missile	Buried. Lid under 3.0 m soil. Bare-lid case is flood/scour, not a missile.
Fire (transport)	10 CFR 71 800°C / 30 min. Glass dump may fire; that is acceptable if k _{eff} stays down.
Design basis excavation	Assume a backhoe can hit the shell. Contact dose on bare shell still a worker number, not a playset number. Keep it low enough for a 1-hour unplanned exposure < 100 mrem. That is another MCNP tally.

12. Materials and manufacturing (all real parts)

Part	Material / spec	Who already makes this class of thing
TRISO-UCO	19.75% U, ASTM / NRC fuel QAP	BWXT, X-energy line
Graphite	Nuclear grade (NBG-18 or equivalent)	GrafTech / Toyo Tanso class
Heat pipes	SS316L or Haynes 230, Na	ACT, Thermacore, space vendors
Inner vessel	SS316L, ASME IX weld, He leak $\leq 1 \times 10^{-8}$ mbar·L/s	Any N-stamp or high-spec vessel shop
BPE	5% boron polyethylene	King / Nuclear-shielding catalogs
Lead	ASTM B29, cast or brick, no voids (X-ray)	Shielding foundries (cask vendors)
Concrete	4,000 psi, 2% borate in inner pour, rebar epoxy	Precast nuclear / cask plants
Outer shell	Carbon steel, coated, or 316	Tank / cask shops
Drums	B ₄ C in SS cladding, geared, lockable	Control-drum vendors, research-reactor shops
Frit dump	Borosilicate + B ₄ C, eutectic plug	Glass + specialty metals
Oil loop	Double-wall A312, Dowtherm A	Process / CSP contractors
Stirling (utility room)	Hermetic free-piston, 2 kWe class	Sunpower / Qnergy class
Inverter / gateway	UL 1741, IEEE 1547	Tesla / Schneider / SolarEdge class
Dry cooler	27 kW air coil	Any HVAC OEM

Factory sequence: fuel compacts → core + pipes + drums → inner vessel (He leak) → BPE pour / tiles → lead pour → concrete precast or poured in a pit form → outer shell → trunnions → seal wires → cold critical (zero-power) at the factory site in a cell → drums locked → ship.

Cold critical at the factory is a real nuclear operation (a licensed facility). The backyard is not that facility.

13. House interfaces (Chapter 4), numbers

Interface	Spec
Electrical	8 kWe nominal, 10 kWe installed convertors, 240 V split-phase after inverter
Battery	27 to 40 kWh, 10 to 15 kW
Hydronic	27 kWth, 80 to 120°F, isolated plate HX, ~7 gpm house water
Dry cooler	27 kW, outdoor
Oil loop	0.40 kg/s, 350°C max, double-wall
Clearances	Grass patch ~10 × 10 ft; setbacks are a local buried-tank permit; dry cooler as a condenser; crane path kept for Chapter 7
Flooded house	Inverter, battery, Stirling above design flood. Vault may be underwater.

14. Safety case in one page (for the reviewer)

1. **Inventory is small.** 35 kWth, 30 kg HM, 1.35 kg fission-equivalent U-235 in 100 years.

2. **Decay heat is a heater.** 2.3 kW at 1 s, 0.3 kW at 1 d, into 42 t and earth.
3. **No pump in the vault.** Heat pipes + earth.
4. **Cannot go prompt on a single fault.** DB-11 + Doppler.
5. **Dose at the grass is a living-on-it number of ≤ 5 mrem/y,** including dry soil and a bare lid, pending MCNP. A playset hour a day is ~ 0.2 mrem/y.
6. **Holes point down.**
7. **Fresh core is cold on the truck.**
8. **Conversion failures trip the core;** they do not open it.
9. **46 t, no float, crane-only access.**
10. **Take-back is a sealed lift** (Chapter 7). Residual HM is still tens of kilograms at a licensed site.

What this does **not** claim: that MCNP has been run, that 10 CFR 71 is passed, that HALEU is contracted, or that a Stirling has run 100 years. Those are §16.

15. Security and material control (high level)

- 30 kg of 19.75% U is HALEU. Attractive. Not direct-use HEU.
 - Access: 42 t monolith, IAEA-style seals, no owner hatch, drums locked.
 - Startup source and drum key: two-person, licensed, logged.
 - GPS / tamper on transport.
 - This section is a requirement list, not a how-to.
-

16. What an engineer must still run before a stamp

Work	Code / method	Pass / fail
Lattice, drums, flood, temperature coefficients	MCNP6 or Serpent + SCALE/KENO	§3.4 table
Depletion 100 y	ORIGEN / Serpent depletion	$k_{\text{eff}}(\text{EOL}) \geq 1$ with drums; peak burnup ≤ 80 GWd/t
Shield, chase, bare lid, dry sand	MCNP6	DB-5, DB-6, chase 50 $\mu\text{rem/h}$
Heat pipes (startup, fail, freeze)	Transient HP model + 1 failed-pipe test	35 kW with 2 pipes out
Vessel, pad, lift, seismic	ASME VIII or III, ASCE 7/43	Stress < allowables
Type B package	10 CFR 71	Drop, fire, immersion
Oil loop fire / leak	NFPA / local	Double-wall, detected
Stirling + inverter	UL / IEEE 1547	Listing
TRISO qualification	Existing AGR/HTGR data + lot tests	Failure fraction vs source term
Glass dump	Furnace mockup	Flows, B worth, no vessel cut
Cold critical	Licensed cell	Matches model
Environmental (NEPA etc.)	Legal	Not this file

Until those rows are green, this is a **design specification**, not a signed reactor.

17. Risks that are real

Risk	Why it is real	Mitigation in this spec
100-year convertor	Not demonstrated	Convertor is in the utility room
100-year graphite / TRISO in this flux	Data exist for shorter, hotter cores	Low power density; still need a materials memo
HALEU supply	US capacity is thin	30 kg/unit is small; still a contract risk
Type B + first-of-a-kind license	Cost and years	Chapter 6; size argument
Oil at 350°C in a yard	Fire	Double-wall, buried, trip on leak
Sell-back	Utility, not physics	Chapter 2
Public dose if someone cheats the BPE	Dirt is not the shield	DB-6 bare lid

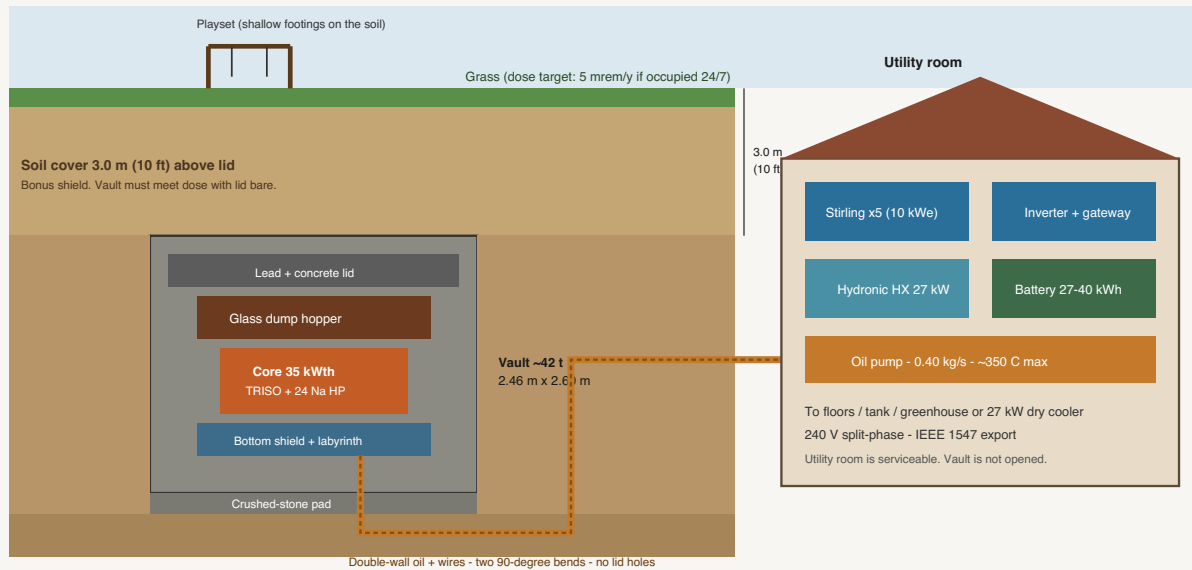
18. Diagrams

Vector drawings live in /diagrams/. They are type-unit schematics, not fabrication drawings. Dimensions match §§3, 6, and 8.

18.1 Site section

Figure 1. Site section, BGS-8 (not to construction scale)

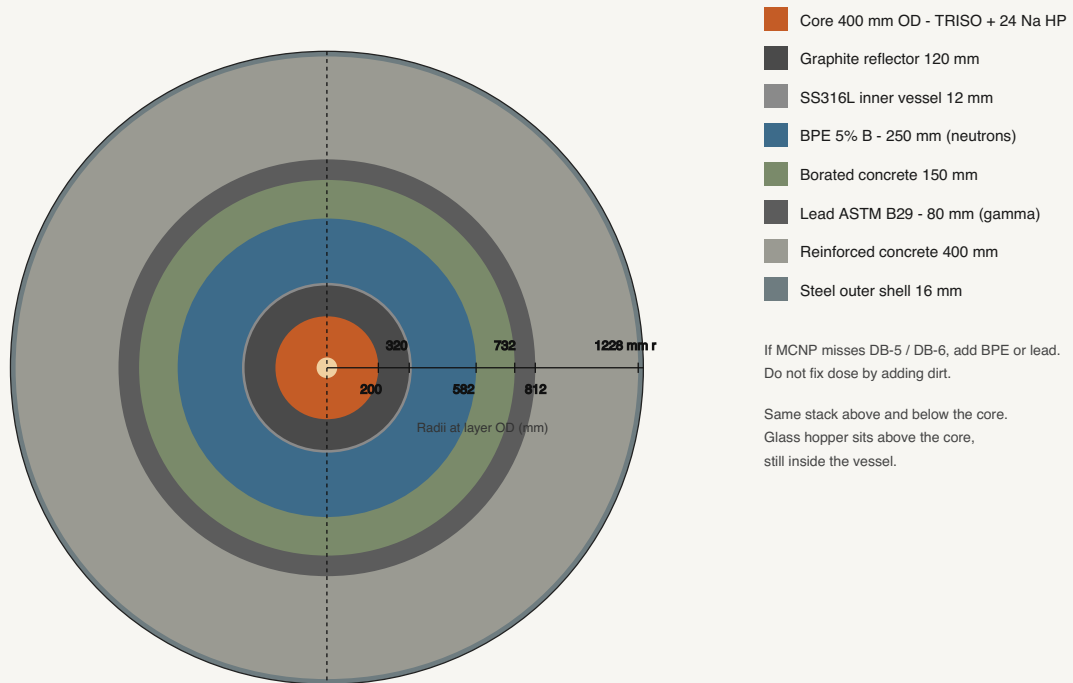
10 ft (3.0 m) of soil above the lid. Vault 2.46 m OD x 2.60 m H. Chase floor-only, two 90-degree bends. Utility room is replaceable.



18.2 Radial stack

Figure 2. Radial shield stack (half-section, type unit)

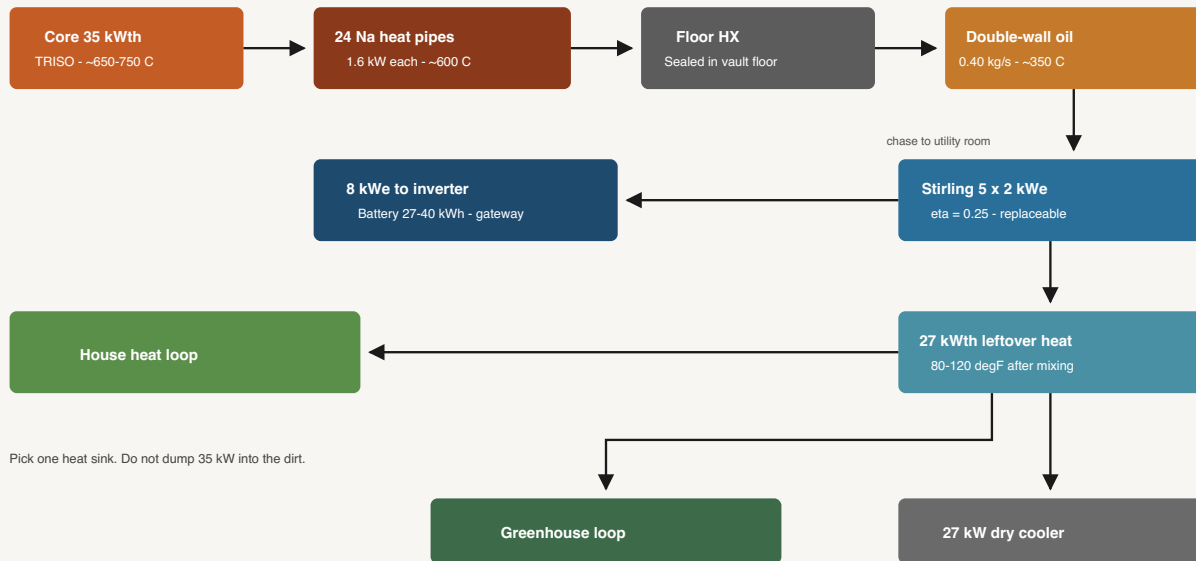
Outer diameter 2.46 m. Layers ordered so capture gammas born in BPE hit lead next. Soil is not shown; it is bonus above the lid.



18.3 Heat and power

Figure 3. Heat and power cascade

35 kWth in the vault. 8 kWe and 27 kWth out at the utility room. No shaft in the vault.

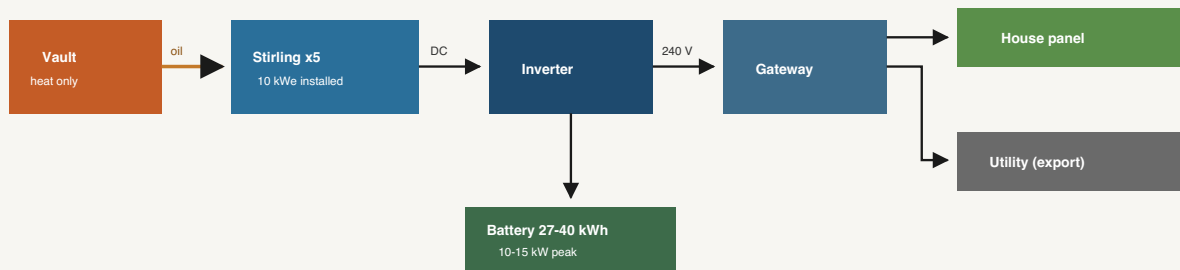


If the oil pump or Stirling units stop, condenser temperature rises and analog drum springs drive shutdown. Decay heat then goes to the vault mass and earth.

18.4 Electrical one-line

Figure 4. Electrical one-line

Vault is heat-only. Stirling, inverter, gateway, and battery live in the utility room. Gateway required so the house can run when the street is dark.

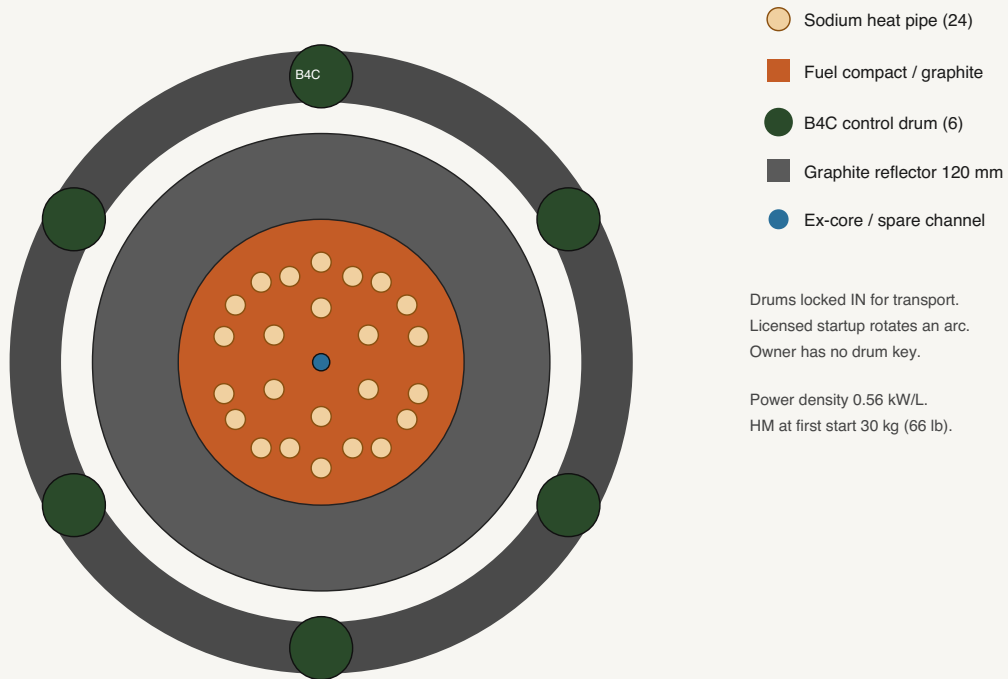


Without the gateway the inverter trips when the grid dies (anti-islanding). Chapter 1 life-safety case requires the gateway.

18.5 Core plan

Figure 5. Core plan (schematic, not a fabrication drawing)

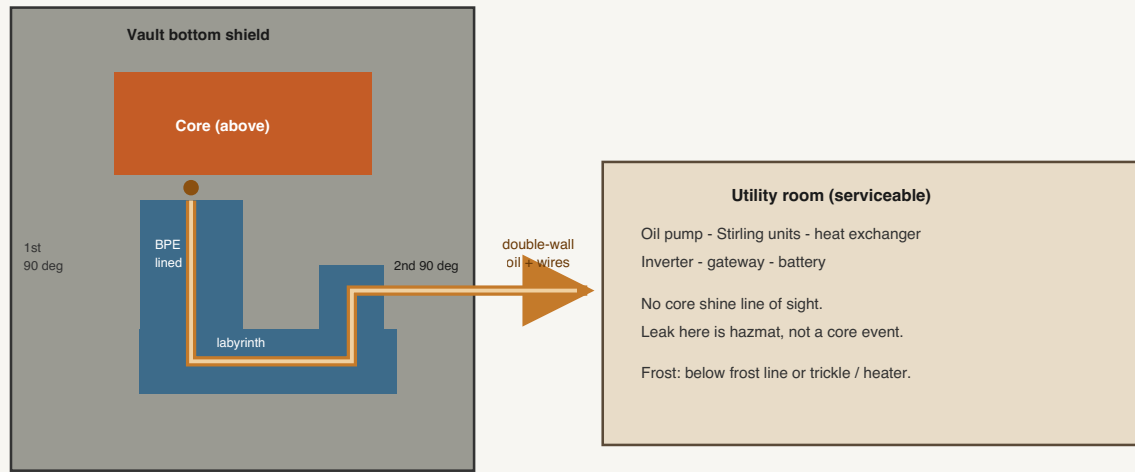
400 mm active OD. 24 sodium heat pipes. Fuel compacts in graphite. 6 B4C drums in the reflector. Exact lattice is an MCNP item.



18.6 Floor chase

Figure 6. Floor chase labyrinth

No straight line from the core to the grass. Two 90-degree bends, BPE-lined. Streaming is an MCNP tally (50 microrem/h or less at the house-end pipe).



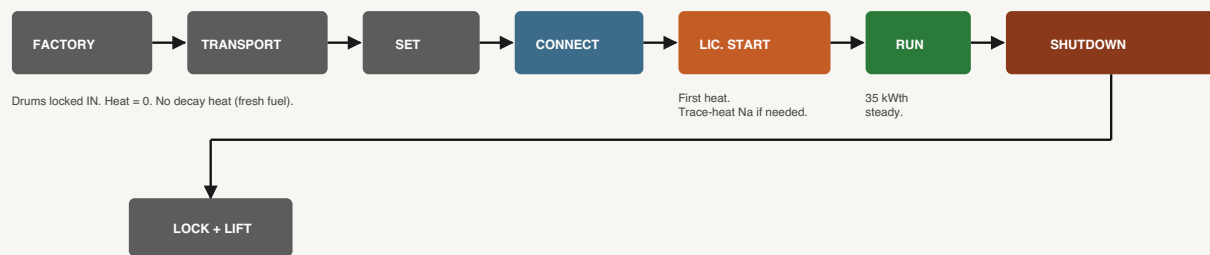
Forbidden: any hole through the lid (would point at the playset).

Allowed through floor only: 2 x oil (process + containment), instrument bundle, startup-heater power (locked out after start), ground.

18.7 States

Figure 7. Vault states

Fresh fuel is cold on the truck. First heat is licensed startup after burial. Locks in before the crane returns.

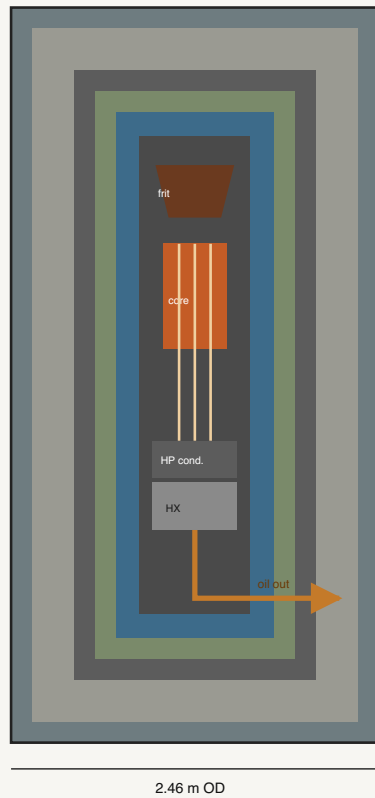


Overtemp or licensed trip drives drums IN (analog, two channels). Wait until decay heat < 0.4 kW (~1 day) before lift. Owner phone cannot move drums.

18.8 Vertical cutaway

Figure 8. Vault vertical cutaway

2.60 m outer height. Same shield above and below the core. Hopper is last-ditch only (plug 750 C). No owner hatch.



Top to bottom

Steel skin 16 mm
 Concrete 400 mm
 Lead 80 mm
 Borated concrete 150 mm
 BPE 250 mm
 Graphite / vessel

Glass hopper (80 kg frit + 15 kg B4C)
 Fusible plug 750 +/- 20 C

Core 400 x 500 mm - 35 kWth
 24 Na heat pipes to condenser

Floor HX - oil out via labyrinth

Mass ~42 t - will not float
 No lid hatch

10 ft soil above lid (not shown)
 Dose designed with lid bare

19. Type-unit data sheet (BGS-8)

Electrical, net	8.0 kWe (family 5 to 10)
Thermal	35 kWth
Conversion	Utility-room Stirling, $\eta = 0.25$, 5×2 kWe
Reject	27 kWth
Fuel	TRISO-UCO, 19.75% U-235, 30 kg HM (66 lb)
Burnup target	80 GWd/t
Life	100 y sealed, $\geq 90\%$ CF
Core	400 mm $\times$ 500 mm, 0.56 kW/L
Heat pipes	24 $\times$ 1.6 kW, sodium
Vault OD $\times$ H	2.46 m $\times$ 2.60 m
Mass	~ 42 t (93,000 lb)
Cover	3.0 m (10 ft) soil above lid (dose still lid-bare)
Dose, live-on-grass	≤ 5 mrem/y (MCNP to confirm)
Dose, 1 h/d playset	~ 0.2 mrem/y
Flood	Immersion OK, no float
Penetrations	Floor only
Owner hatch	None

20. What this chapter covered

This is the vault and core **design specification**: power, fuel, pipes, layers, mass, dose targets, states, and buyable parts. Chapter 5 is the same machine in English. Chapter 3 is the grass. Chapter 4 is the utility room. Chapter 6 is the stamp. Chapter 7 is the crane.

The arithmetic in §2, §3.3, §4.1, §4.3, §6.1, §6.5, §8 is closed.

Rechecked in version 1.0: $8 \text{ kWe} / 0.25 = 32 \text{ kWth}$, specified 35 kWth; $8 \times 8,760 = 70,080 \text{ kWh/y}$; $35 \text{ kW} \times 100 \text{ y} = 1,278 \text{ MWd}$; 16 kg consumed at 80 GWd/t; 30 kg at first start; $24 \times 1.6 \text{ kW} = 38.4 \text{ kW}$ pipes; oil 0.40 kg/s; vault ~42 t, will not float; playset $5 \times 365/8,760 = 0.21 \text{ mrem/y}$. The dose **stack** in §6.3 is an engineering starting geometry. The **dose number** on the lawn is a requirement until MCNP says it is a result.

If a line in this file and a line in Chapter 5 disagree, this file wins for engineering, and Chapter 5 should be updated to match (heavy metal at first start is 30 kg, not 10 kg).